

Are galaxies in compact groups special?

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ABSTRACT

Context. Compact groups of galaxies combine high projected densities with low velocity dispersions, but many are embedded in, or projected onto, larger structures. Their evolutionary significance depends on whether their member galaxies remain distinct from those of comparable regular groups, not only from the field.

Aims. We test whether galaxies in compact groups of four members (CG₄) remain special against regular groups of four members (RG₄), the four brightest galaxies of richer regular groups (Control_{4B}), and projected compact cores formed by the brightest group galaxy (BGG) and its three nearest projected companions (Control_{4C}). We ask which observable carries any residual signal.

Methods. From our previously constructed samples, we retain 62 CG₄ systems after removing split systems. We combine Galaxy Zoo vote-fraction morphologies, Sloan Digital Sky Survey stellar masses and specific star-formation rates, optical colours, emission-line diagnostics, and seeing-corrected half-light radii (with Petrosian radii as a cross-check), analysed with covariate-adjusted, group-clustered binomial models and one-to-one matched controls.

Results. CG₄ galaxies, especially satellites, are more often smooth/elliptical and less often spiral than their regular-group analogues. In separate per-control models the signal is strong against Control_{4B} and RG₄ but not against the projected cores Control_{4C}; matched CG₄ groups host a higher smooth-satellite fraction than matched control groups, while the galaxy-level matched contrast is not significant once group membership is respected. The signal is stable against the vote-fraction threshold and a Sérsic-index cross-check, and CG₄ members show no morphology excess over other members of their own host groups. The star-formation deficit of CG₄ satellites is not comparably robust, and star-forming CG₄ galaxies show no robust main-sequence offset. Colours, active-galactic-nucleus fractions, magnitude gaps, and H α diagnostics do not support instantaneous-quenching, fossil-group, or AGN-driven explanations. Conditioning on a projected pairwise tidal index attenuates the morphology signal, indicating a contrast concentrated in the most extreme local projected configurations. No robust CG₄ size offset at fixed stellar mass is established.

Conclusions. Compact groups host a more morphologically evolved population, consistent with accumulated transformation in dense group cores and/or preprocessing, rather than a uniquely isolated compact-group quenching mode at the present epoch.

Key words. galaxies: groups: general – galaxies: evolution – galaxies: interactions – galaxies: star formation – galaxies: elliptical and lenticular, cD – methods: statistical

1. Introduction

Compact groups of galaxies are useful laboratories for environmental evolution because they combine high projected galaxy densities with relatively low velocity dispersions (Hickson 1982; Hickson et al. 1992). Mendes de Oliveira & Hickson (1994) provided the classic report of an excess of early-type galaxies in compact groups relative to the field. In such configurations, repeated tidal encounters, dynamical friction, mergers, gas stripping or consumption, and disk heating can plausibly accelerate the transformation of galaxies compared with more diffuse environments (Barnes 1985, 1989; Verdes-Montenegro et al. 2001). This expectation is closely

connected to the broader morphology-density and star-formation-environment relation, in which galaxy structure and star-formation activity vary systematically with local density (Dressler 1980). Multi-wavelength studies of compact-group galaxies likewise report altered infrared, UV, star-formation, and population properties relative to looser environments (Johnson et al. 2007; Walker et al. 2010; Tzanavaris et al. 2010; Bitsakis et al. 2010, 2011; Coenda et al. 2012; Plauchu-Frayn et al. 2012).

The interpretation of compact groups is nevertheless ambiguous. Projected selection can include chance alignments, and many Hickson-like systems need not be isolated bound entities. Simulations and redshift-space analyses have long shown that apparent compact groups may be transient alignments, dense substructures, or cores embedded in looser groups and richer haloes (Mamon 1986; Díaz-Giménez & Mamon 2010; Díaz-Giménez et al.

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2012; Díaz-Giménez et al. 2020; Zheng & Shen 2021; Taverna et al. 2023). The relevant observational question is therefore not only whether compact-group galaxies differ from field galaxies, but whether they remain different from galaxies occupying regular-group analogues selected with comparable luminosity, redshift, and membership constraints.

Recent structural work strengthens this motivation. Using S-PLUS imaging and single-Sérsic measurements, Montaguth et al. (2023, 2025, 2026a,b) identified transition galaxies and trends in the R_e -Sérsic-index plane that point to structural transformation in compact groups, with stronger signatures in non-isolated compact groups and host structures. These studies suggest that compact groups can mark sites of cumulative structural processing. They do not, however, by themselves answer whether compact-group galaxies remain distinct after comparison with regular-group cores selected from the same parent catalogues.

Our previous work (Tricottet et al. 2025) addressed the question of whether compact groups are special as dynamical systems. We found that, once the direct consequences of the compact-group selection are accounted for, compact groups of four galaxies have group-scale properties broadly similar to those of regular groups of four galaxies and to the cores of richer regular groups. This motivates the complementary question addressed here: even if compact groups are not strongly distinct as systems, are their member galaxies individually different? We therefore use the same compact-group and regular-group framework to compare galaxies rather than groups, controlling for stellar mass, redshift, galaxy rank, and available group-scale properties. We then identify which observable, if any, carries the residual compact-group signal: star-formation class, Galaxy Zoo morphology, optical colour, AGN-like activity, fossil-like magnitude gaps, projected phase-space position, or local projected tidal density.

The paper is organized as follows. Section 2 describes the samples, the sSFR and morphology classifications, and the statistical hierarchy. Sections 3 and 4 present baseline population differences and group-scale diagnostics. Section 5 tests which signals survive adjusted and matched comparisons and examines secondary diagnostics. Section 6 discusses the physical interpretation of the morphology signal, and Section 7 summarizes the conclusions.

2. Data and classifications

2.1. Samples

We use the compact-group and control samples constructed in our previous study (Tricottet et al. 2025). We briefly recall their construction here. Galaxy properties are taken from the SDSS DR12 catalogue of Tempel et al. (2017), while regular groups are drawn from the SDSS DR7 group catalogue of Lim et al. (2017); the two catalogues were matched through SDSS object identifiers to define the Lim–Tempel working catalogue. Compact groups are selected from the modified Hickson compact-group catalogue of Díaz-Giménez et al. (2018). Starting from the reliable HMCs with exactly four members, we retain only systems in which all galaxies are present in the Lim–Tempel catalogue and impose the volume- and luminosity-complete limits $0.005 < z_{\text{BGG}} < 0.0452$ and $M_{r,\text{BGG}} \leq -21.81$, with all 4 galaxies lying within 3 magnitudes of the brightest

group galaxy. This defines the parent CG₄ sample of 78 compact groups. The regular-group comparison samples are built from Lim–Tempel groups satisfying the same redshift and BGG-luminosity limits, with at least 4 members and at least 3 satellites within 3 magnitudes of the BGG. From this parent control catalogue, we define RG₄ groups as regular groups with exactly four members, excluding systems identical to a CG₄, and we additionally use the Control_{4B} and Control_{4C} samples, formed respectively from the 4 brightest galaxies and from the BGG plus its 3 closest projected companions in each parent regular group. As in our previous paper, every control group containing at least one CG₄ galaxy is excluded from the control samples, so no galaxy appears on both sides of any comparison. The Control_{4C} sample is regenerated for this paper directly from the 765 parent groups (BGG plus the three closest projected companions, followed by the compact-group exclusion, which removes 60 groups)¹. After the explicit Lim group 3688 removal described below, the control samples contain 698 Control_{4B}, 704 Control_{4C}, and 56 RG₄ groups (2792, 2816, and 224 galaxies). The Control_{4B} and Control_{4C} counts differ because the luminosity-ranked and projected-distance-ranked core definitions select different galaxies and therefore retain different Lim groups after the compact-group exclusion. In contrast to our previous study, we remove CGs classified as *split* following Zheng & Shen (2021). This reduces the compact-group sample from 78 to 62 groups. We also remove the systems associated with Lim group 3688 from our Control_{4B} and Control_{4C} samples. This group contains 6 galaxies with redshifts between 0.032 and 0.034, and 1 with a redshift of 0.048. This group appears to be spurious, and the outlying galaxy, although not the BGG, is selected in both our original Control_{4B} and Control_{4C} samples, significantly affecting the group velocity dispersion (1979 and 1981 km s^{−1}, respectively).

The three regular-group controls serve different physical purposes. RG₄ contains true regular groups with exactly four selected members and is the most direct four-member regular-group comparison. Control_{4B} contains the four brightest galaxies in richer regular groups and tests whether the CG₄ population resembles the luminous core of an ordinary group. Control_{4C} contains the BGG plus the three closest projected companions and is the most compact-core-like ordinary-group analogue. CG₄ is therefore tested against both equal-membership groups and regular-group cores, rather than against a single control definition.

We use SDSS DR16 (Ahumada et al. 2020) to retrieve stellar masses, star formation rates (SFRs; Brinchmann et al. 2004; Kauffmann et al. 2003b), and Galaxy Zoo morphologies (Lintott et al. 2008, 2011). We specifically extract the columns `sfr_tot_p50`, `specsfr_tot_p50`, and `lgm_tot_p50` from the `galSpecExtra` table, and `p_el_debiased` and `p_cs_debiased` from the `zooSpec` table. In the SDSS query, `galSpecExtra`, `galSpecLine`, and `zooSpec` are joined to `SpecObj` by `specObjID`, while the photometric object is linked through `SpecObj.bestObjID=PhotoObj.objID`; the queried quan-

¹ Our previous paper quotes 61 excluded projected-core groups; the committed parent catalogue reproducibly yields 60. The difference traces to an earlier revision of the parent catalogue and does not affect any comparison in this paper.

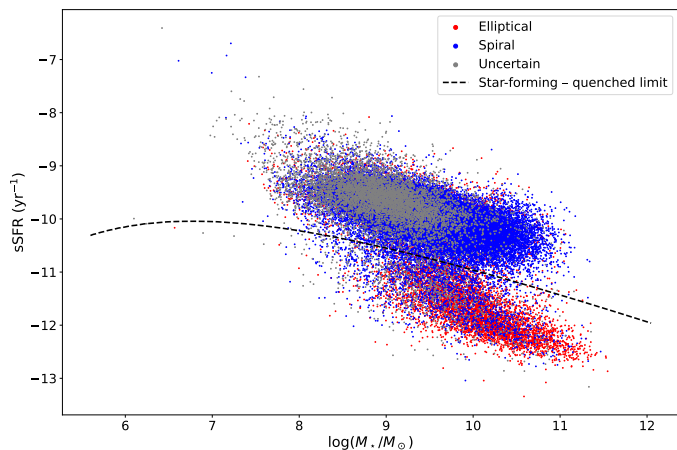


Fig. 1. sSFR versus stellar mass, the star-forming/quenched limit, and Galaxy Zoo morphologies for the SDSS selection, excluding galaxies without sSFR estimates.

ties are then merged onto the CG and control catalogue rows by their stored objid.

Throughout, ‘SDSS selection’ denotes the reference sample returned by the query of Appendix A: all spectroscopic galaxies with $0.005 \leq z \leq 0.0452$, extinction-corrected Petrosian $r \leq 17.77$, a valid MPA-JHU stellar mass, and Galaxy Zoo classifications. It serves as a field-dominated reference population, not as a control sample.

All projected distances and derived quantities adopt the Planck 2015 cosmology (Planck Collaboration et al. 2016), consistently with our previous paper (Tricottet et al. 2025).

2.2. sSFR classification

We classify galaxies from SDSS total sSFRs using the query reported in Appendix A (Listing 1). In the MPA-JHU tables, `specsfr_tot_p50 = -9999` flags galaxies without a valid sSFR estimate rather than measured zero star formation; we therefore treat such galaxies as *missing data*: they are excluded from the star-formation classification, from every sSFR-based figure and fraction, and are reported as counts only (Table 1). All quenched and star-forming fractions quoted in this paper are computed among classified galaxies only. The missing-sSFR incidence is markedly higher in CG₄ (7% of members, and 10% of BGGs) than in the field selection (1%), plausibly reflecting the crowded-field spectroscopy and deblending issues discussed in Sect. 6.4 rather than a physical population. Galaxies with a measured sSFR are split into quenched and star-forming classes with a two-component GMM in the $\log M_\star$ - $\log$ sSFR plane. BPT/AGN handling and the exact GMM boundary definition are given in Appendix B.

2.3. Morphology classification

Morphologies are determined via the Galaxy Zoo citizen-science decision tree, in which each galaxy image receives multiple independent volunteer classifications that are aggregated into debiased vote fractions (Lintott et al. 2008, 2011). Those fractions are provided in the `zooSpec` table of the SDSS database through the `p_el_debiased` and `p_cs_debiased` columns. We classify a galaxy as “elliptical/smooth” if `p_el_debiased` is greater than 0.5, and as

“spiral/features” if `p_cs_debiased` is greater than 0.5. All other cases are classified as “uncertain”. These are vote-fraction classes, not a full structural decomposition. In particular, the catalogue used here does not provide a clean E/S0 separation, so references below to elliptical or early-type galaxies should be read as Galaxy Zoo smooth/early-type proxies rather than as a bulge-disc structural classification.

2.4. Galaxy sizes

Our primary galaxy-size measure is the circular half-light radius of the pure Sérsic fit in the r band, $R_{\text{chl},r}$, from the bulge+disk decomposition catalogue of Simard et al. (2011). These are PSF-convolved GIM2D fits with re-derived sky levels and deblending designed with crowded fields in mind, which is the relevant regime for compact-group photometry, so the fitted sizes are corrected for seeing. The catalogue is keyed to SDSS DR7 identifiers; we therefore bridge our DR16 objects to their DR7 counterparts through the SkyServer `SpecDR7` cross-match table. Two guards protect this bridge: rows in which the Simard redshift differs from the catalogue redshift by more than 0.005 are treated as wrong matches and their structural values are dropped (15 rows), and rows in which two distinct catalogue galaxies of the same group resolve to a single DR7 identifier are treated as blended DR7 detections and dropped (0 rows). The Simard sizes are tabulated in kpc under the catalogue’s own cosmology; we convert them back to angular sizes with the catalogue plate scale and then to proper kpc with the same Planck 2015 conversion as every other projected quantity in this paper (Sect. 2.1).

As a secondary size measure we use the SDSS Petrosian radii `petroR50_r` and `petroR90_r`, which also define the concentration index $C = R_{90,r}/R_{50,r}$. Petrosian radii are not corrected for seeing, and the SDSS Petrosian aperture misses a profile-dependent fraction of the flux, roughly 20% for an $n = 4$ profile, which biases $R_{50,r}$ low for concentrated galaxies (Blanton et al. 2001; Graham et al. 2005) – precisely the smooth/early-type-like population in which CG₄ is enhanced. The Petrosian measure is nevertheless retained because it is model-independent, essentially fully available, and provides the like-for-like bridge to the compact-group size study of Coenda et al. (2012). All sizes are required to lie between 0.1 and 50 kpc after re-conversion; Sérsic fits pegged at the GIM2D bounds ($n_g \leq 0.55$ or $n_g \geq 7.9$; 63 galaxies) are excluded from the primary sample, and Petrosian entries must satisfy $R_{50,r} > 0$, $R_{90,r} > R_{50,r}$, and a finite positive uncertainty. The completeness of both measures, and its difference between CG₄ and the controls, is audited in Sect. 5.12.

2.5. Statistical strategy

The analyses are organized hierarchically. Raw tables and exact tests provide descriptive baseline comparisons. Fisher or Barnard exact tests are used for two-sample categorical comparisons depending on the table structure, while rank-sum or bootstrap comparisons are used for distributional and median differences. Spearman and Pearson correlations are used only as diagnostics of monotonic or linear trends; when the coefficients are small, we interpret them as weak even if the p-values are formally small. Holm or

Benjamini–Hochberg corrections are applied where multiple related tests are performed.

The primary inference layer consists of mass-, rank-, and environment-adjusted binomial models fit *separately* for each CG₄–control pair (Sect. 5.1), and of a group-level matched comparison in which groups, not galaxies, are the units. Throughout, the independence unit is the *physical* group: standard errors are clustered by Lim group (unifying the overlapping control definitions, with CG₄ systems assigned to their host Lim group), and all resampling is blocked at the group level, since the four galaxies of one group are not independent observations. Pooled models across the three controls are reported as secondary summaries only, after deduplicating the overlapping control samples to one row per physical galaxy. Bootstrap p-values use the add-one empirical convention $p = (k + 1)/(B + 1)$ with the number of resamples B reported, so no resampling p-value can fall below its Monte-Carlo resolution; displayed p-values are floored at 10^{-4} . Colours, AGN-like fractions, H α equivalent widths, magnitude gaps, crossing-time trends, projected phase space, and the pairwise tidal index are secondary diagnostics. The main conclusions below rely on signals that survive the per-control adjusted and matched analyses, not on isolated exploratory tests.

3. Baseline population differences

3.1. Raw sSFR fractions

The sSFR status for each sample is shown in Table 1. In the raw all-galaxy comparison, Fisher’s exact test gives star-forming-fraction p-values of $p = 0.481$ versus the Control_{4B} sample, $p = 0.184$ versus Control_{4C}, and $p = 3 \times 10^{-4}$ versus RG₄. We treat these raw tests as descriptive because they do not adjust for stellar mass, rank, or group-scale differences.

The same comparison restricted to BGGs and satellites is also shown in Table 1. For BGGs, the p-values obtained with two-sided Fisher exact test are $p = 0.578$ against Control_{4B}, $p = 0.576$ against Control_{4C} and $p = 0.37$ against RG₄. For satellites, the corresponding p-values are $p = 0.302$ against Control_{4B}, $p = 0.069$ against Control_{4C} and $p = 2.3 \times 10^{-4}$ against RG₄. The satellite deficit is clearest in the raw comparison with RG₄ and is revisited below with adjusted and matched analyses.

3.2. Raw morphology fractions

The morphologies obtained for each sample are shown in Table 2. Barnard’s two-sided exact tests were used to compare the fraction of each morphology between CG₄ and each control sample. The resulting p-values are $p = 1.4 \times 10^{-3}$ for ellipticals and $p = 1.2 \times 10^{-3}$ for spirals versus the Control_{4B} sample, $p = 6.4 \times 10^{-3}$ and $p = 0.074$ versus Control_{4C} and $p < 10^{-4}$ and $p < 10^{-4}$ versus RG₄. The galaxies in CG₄ systems, which we identified as cores of richer groups in Tricottet et al. (2025), show a robust raw excess of elliptical/smooth classifications and a deficit of spiral/features classifications. Figure 2 displays sSFR versus stellar mass for galaxies in the SDSS selection and in CG₄.

Table 1. Number of galaxies in each sSFR class for each sample. Galaxies without a valid sSFR estimate (‘No sSFR’) are excluded from the classification: their percentages are quoted with respect to all galaxies of the (sub)sample, while the quenched and star-forming percentages are quoted with respect to classified galaxies only.

Sample	No sSFR	Quenched	Star-forming
CG ₄	18 (7%)	146 (63%)	84 (37%)
BGG	6 (10%)	45 (80%)	11 (20%)
Satellites	12 (6%)	101 (58%)	73 (42%)
Control _{4B}	180 (6%)	1593 (61%)	1019 (39%)
BGG	58 (8%)	533 (83%)	107 (17%)
Satellites	122 (6%)	1060 (54%)	912 (46%)
Control _{4C}	179 (6%)	1551 (59%)	1086 (41%)
BGG	59 (8%)	538 (83%)	107 (17%)
Satellites	120 (6%)	1013 (51%)	979 (49%)
RG ₄	5 (2%)	101 (46%)	118 (54%)
BGG	3 (5%)	38 (72%)	15 (28%)
Satellites	2 (1%)	63 (38%)	103 (62%)
SDSS selection	634 (1%)	7705 (15%)	44192 (85%)

Table 2. Number of galaxies in each Galaxy Zoo vote-fraction morphology proxy for each sample.

Sample	Elliptical/ smooth	Spiral/ features	Uncertain
CG ₄	124 (50%)	86 (35%)	38 (15%)
Control _{4B}	1106 (40%)	1266 (45%)	420 (15%)
Control _{4C}	1157 (41%)	1140 (40%)	519 (18%)
RG ₄	60 (27%)	129 (58%)	35 (16%)
SDSS selection	10091 (19%)	34715 (66%)	7725 (15%)

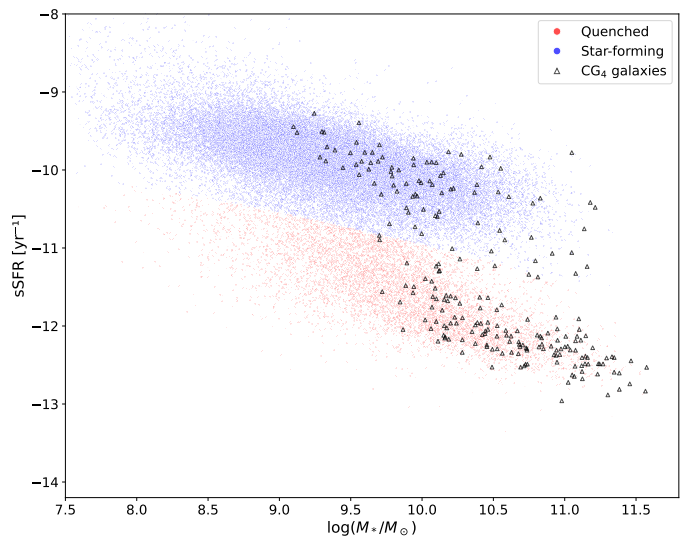


Fig. 2. sSFR and morphologies of galaxies in CG₄ and our SDSS selection. Galaxies without a valid sSFR estimate are excluded from this figure.

3.3. Morphology versus sSFR

Among star-forming CG₄ galaxies, 58 are classified as spiral (84.1% after removing galaxies with uncertain morphology) and 11 are classified as elliptical (15.9% after removing galaxies with uncertain morphology). The corresponding numbers are 810 spiral galaxies (88.4%) and 106 elliptical galaxies (11.6%) for Control_{4B}, 773 spiral galaxies

Table 3. Median values of galaxy properties for quenched and star-forming populations in each sample. Uncertainties are estimated by bootstrapping (10 000 iterations). sSFR is in yr^{-1} , and stellar mass is in $M_{\odot}$.

Sample	Quantity	Quenched	Star-forming
CG4	$\log_{10} \text{sSFR}$	-12.08 ± 0.03	-10.19 ± 0.07
	M_r	-21.16 ± 0.14	-20.4 ± 0.14
	$\log M_{\star}$	10.64 ± 0.07	10.05 ± 0.05
Control4B	$\log_{10} \text{sSFR}$	-12.1 ± 0.01	-10.31 ± 0.02
	M_r	-21.52 ± 0.04	-20.75 ± 0.04
	$\log M_{\star}$	10.79 ± 0.01	10.24 ± 0.02
Control4C	$\log_{10} \text{sSFR}$	-11.93 ± 0.02	-10.18 ± 0.02
	M_r	-20.81 ± 0.06	-19.95 ± 0.04
	$\log M_{\star}$	10.47 ± 0.03	9.84 ± 0.02
RG4	$\log_{10} \text{sSFR}$	-11.91 ± 0.07	-10.16 ± 0.07
	M_r	-21.11 ± 0.25	-20.32 ± 0.12
	$\log M_{\star}$	10.62 ± 0.08	9.97 ± 0.09

Table 4. Median values of various quantities for galaxies according to the sSFR class of their BGG (BGG included). Uncertainties are estimated by bootstrapping (10 000 iterations). sSFR is in yr^{-1} , and stellar mass is in $M_{\odot}$.

Sample	Quantity	BGG quenched	BGG SF
CG4	$\log_{10} \text{sSFR}$	-11.53 ± 0.09	-10.85 ± 0.29
	M_r	-20.93 ± 0.11	-20.77 ± 0.32
	$\log M_{\star}$	10.46 ± 0.06	10.32 ± 0.12
Control4B	$\log_{10} \text{sSFR}$	-11.52 ± 0.03	-10.86 ± 0.06
	M_r	-21.25 ± 0.03	-21.12 ± 0.07
	$\log M_{\star}$	10.61 ± 0.02	10.46 ± 0.04
Control4C	$\log_{10} \text{sSFR}$	-11.33 ± 0.04	-10.65 ± 0.07
	M_r	-20.45 ± 0.05	-20.59 ± 0.08
	$\log M_{\star}$	10.24 ± 0.02	10.19 ± 0.06
RG4	$\log_{10} \text{sSFR}$	-11.14 ± 0.19	-10.58 ± 0.16
	M_r	-20.69 ± 0.14	-20.74 ± 0.28
	$\log M_{\star}$	10.32 ± 0.07	10.19 ± 0.12

Table 5. Median values of various quantities for galaxies according to the sSFR class of their BGG (satellites only). Uncertainties are estimated by bootstrapping (10 000 iterations). sSFR is in yr^{-1} , and stellar mass is in $M_{\odot}$.

Sample	Quantity	BGG quenched	BGG SF
CG4	$\log_{10} \text{sSFR}$	-11.23 ± 0.16	-10.92 ± 0.48
	M_r	-20.45 ± 0.13	-20.34 ± 0.18
	$\log M_{\star}$	10.22 ± 0.05	10.09 ± 0.06
Control4B	$\log_{10} \text{sSFR}$	-11.25 ± 0.06	-10.91 ± 0.13
	M_r	-20.9 ± 0.03	-20.75 ± 0.06
	$\log M_{\star}$	10.43 ± 0.02	10.3 ± 0.03
Control4C	$\log_{10} \text{sSFR}$	-10.99 ± 0.04	-10.62 ± 0.09
	M_r	-19.82 ± 0.04	-20.05 ± 0.09
	$\log M_{\star}$	9.92 ± 0.02	9.93 ± 0.06
RG4	$\log_{10} \text{sSFR}$	-10.82 ± 0.19	-10.61 ± 0.22
	M_r	-20.23 ± 0.16	-20.3 ± 0.13
	$\log M_{\star}$	10.09 ± 0.08	10 ± 0.13

(84.3%) and 144 elliptical galaxies (15.7%) for Control_{4C}, and 91 spiral galaxies (91%) and 9 elliptical galaxies (9%) for RG₄. The probabilities that these fractions are drawn from the same distribution, estimated with Barnard two-sided exact test, are $p = 0.283$ against Control_{4B}, $p = 0.964$ against Control_{4C}, and $p = 0.186$ against RG₄. We therefore find neither a significant excess nor a deficit of star-forming elliptical galaxies in CG₄ relative to any control sample.

When restricting the comparison to BGGs, we find 36 elliptical BGGs (58.1% of the BGGs) and 17 spiral BGGs (27.4%) in CG₄. The corresponding numbers are 405 elliptical BGGs (58.0%) and 195 spiral BGGs (27.9%) in Control_{4B}, 409 elliptical BGGs (58.1%) and 195 spiral BGGs (27.7%) in Control_{4C}, and 21 elliptical BGGs (37.5%) and 26 spiral BGGs (46.4%) in RG₄. The p -values obtained with two-sided Fisher exact test are 1.00 against Control_{4B}, 1.00 against Control_{4C} and 0.03 against RG₄. Thus, BGG morphologies differ between CG₄ and RG₄: CG₄ BGGs have a higher elliptical fraction than RG₄ BGGs.

3.4. Population medians by sSFR class

Tables 3–5 summarize the typical stellar masses, absolute magnitudes, and sSFRs of quenched and star-forming galaxies, including splits by the sSFR class of the BGG. These medians are descriptive and mainly show that star-formation class is entangled with stellar mass and luminosity, motivating the adjusted models below.

3.5. Main sequence

We model the star-forming main sequence as a function of stellar mass using polynomial orders 1–4; the polynomial-order comparison is shown in Appendix Fig. D.4. The diagnostic shown there is the residual RMS scatter, not a formal reduced χ^2 , because no per-galaxy uncertainty model is used. We adopt order 2 because it is the lowest-order model with the smallest five-fold cross-validated RMS scatter (0.30523 dex, compared with 0.30560 dex for order 1). We then use order 2 to compute the residual of each star-forming galaxy with respect to the main sequence, and show their distributions in Fig. 3. A positive residual means higher sSFR at fixed stellar mass relative to the fitted star-forming main sequence.

In the comparisons below, Δ is the CG₄-minus-control median residual; positive values mean that CG₄ star-forming galaxies lie above the fitted main sequence relative to the control. Each quoted interval is the central 68% (16th–84th percentile) bootstrap interval on the median difference, and each p is the two-sided bootstrap sign-crossing probability for the same difference (10 000 resamples). The 68% interval and the two-sided p answer slightly different questions and can therefore appear to disagree near the significance boundary: a 68% interval that excludes zero is compatible with p slightly above 0.05, as for Control_{4B} below.

The median main-sequence residual of CG₄ galaxies is:

- marginally different from that of Control_{4B}, with a median offset of $\Delta = 0.056$ ($0.028 \leq \Delta \leq 0.098$, 16th–84th percentile bootstrap interval), corresponding to $p = 0.056$.
- significantly different from that of Control_{4C}, with a median offset of $\Delta = 0.087$ ($0.067 \leq \Delta \leq 0.128$, 16th–84th percentile bootstrap interval), corresponding to $p = 0.009$.
- not significantly different from that of RG₄, with a median offset of $\Delta = 0.046$ ($-0.037 \leq \Delta \leq 0.098$, 16th–84th percentile bootstrap interval), corresponding to $p = 0.532$.

Because the raw residual comparison and the matched comparison below condition on different covariate struc-

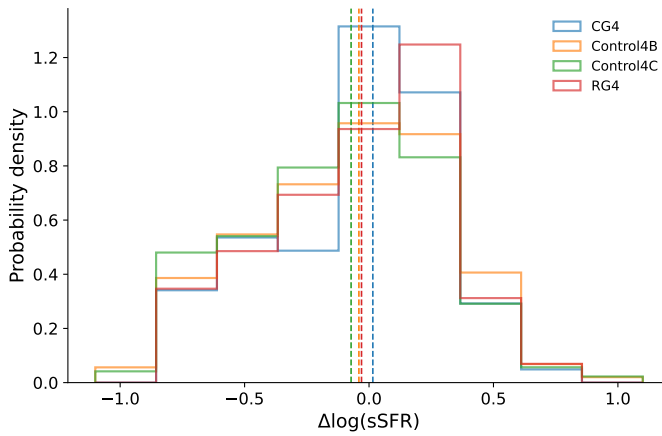


Fig. 3. Main-sequence residual distributions for the star-forming galaxies in each sample.

tures, and because the apparent offset changes in strength and sign after matching, we treat SFMS residuals as a secondary diagnostic rather than as evidence for a robust compact-group star-formation offset.

Within CG₄, the star-forming main-sequence offsets of the Embedded, Isolated and Predominant classes remain statistically consistent with one another.

4. Environmental and group-scale diagnostics

4.1. Distance to the BGG

We also compare the sSFR of satellite galaxies with their distance to the BGG, expressed both in projected kpc and in units of $\langle R_{ij} \rangle$.

Significant monotonic trends are detected in the following cases.

In CG₄, sSFR correlates with projected distance to the BGG with Spearman coefficient $\rho_s = 0.24$ for 174 satellites ($p = 1.5 \times 10^{-3}$) and Pearson coefficient $r = 0.21$ ($p = 5.5 \times 10^{-3}$).

In Control_{4B}, sSFR correlates with distance to the BGG normalized by $\langle R_{ij} \rangle$ with Spearman coefficient $\rho_s = 0.08$ for 1972 satellites ($p = 3.7 \times 10^{-4}$) and Pearson coefficient $r = 0.08$ ($p = 2.4 \times 10^{-4}$).

In Control_{4C}, sSFR correlates with projected distance to the BGG with Spearman coefficient $\rho_s = 0.27$ for 1992 satellites ($p < 10^{-4}$) and Pearson coefficient $r = 0.23$ ($p < 10^{-4}$).

In Control_{4C}, sSFR correlates with distance to the BGG normalized by $\langle R_{ij} \rangle$ with Spearman coefficient $\rho_s = 0.10$ for 1992 satellites ($p < 10^{-4}$) and Pearson coefficient $r = 0.10$ ($p < 10^{-4}$).

The supporting distance plots are shown in Appendix Figs. D.5 and D.6.

4.2. Dominance

We split groups into dominated systems, where the BGG contributes more than 60% of the group luminosity, and non-dominated systems. This split does not produce a strong compact-group signal by itself: CG₄ shows no significant dominated/non-dominated difference after the Benjamini–Hochberg false-discovery-rate (FDR) cor-

rection. Here p_{adj} denotes the FDR-adjusted p-value, and Cliff’s δ is a rank-based effect size ranging from -1 to 1.

Across the control and reference samples, the clearest binary separation is instead in group luminosity. Dominated systems have lower L_{group} than their non-dominated counterparts: Control_{4B} gives 9.1×10^{10} versus $1.28 \times 10^{11} L_{\odot}$ ($p_{\text{adj}} < 10^{-4}$, $\delta = -0.55$); Control_{4C} gives 8.73×10^{10} versus $9.98 \times 10^{10} L_{\odot}$ ($p_{\text{adj}} < 10^{-4}$, $\delta = -0.32$); and RG₄ gives 7.09×10^{10} versus $9.82 \times 10^{10} L_{\odot}$ ($p_{\text{adj}} = 1 \times 10^{-4}$, $\delta = -0.59$). The negative δ values mean that dominated groups tend to occupy the lower-luminosity side of each comparison.

The spiral-fraction correlations show a broader environmental pattern rather than a clean dominated/non-dominated dichotomy. The most coherent set appears in Control_{4C}, where S_{frac} increases with $\langle R_{ij} \rangle$ in both dominated and non-dominated groups ($\rho_s = 0.40$, $p < 10^{-4}$ and $\rho_s = 0.38$, $p < 10^{-4}$), while weaker negative trends are found with σ_v and L_{group} . Control_{4B} contributes only weaker non-dominated-group correlations. In CG₄, the significant trends occur in small subsets, with S_{frac} decreasing with L_{group} among dominated groups ($\rho_s = -0.50$, 36 groups) and with $\Delta V_{\text{BGG}}/\sigma_v$ among non-dominated groups ($\rho_s = -0.53$, 26 groups); we therefore treat these as supporting diagnostics rather than the main dominance result. The full distributional and correlation diagnostics are shown in Appendix Figs. D.7 and D.8.

4.3. Morphology and domination

When we further split the samples by domination and by the morphology of the BGG, significant effects only appear in the following cases.

- Control_{4B} dominated groups, where the median satellite spiral fraction is 1.00 for spiral BGGs and 0.67 for elliptical BGGs. The association between BGG morphology and satellite spiral fraction has a group-level odds ratio of 1.842 ($p = 0.01$) in this sample; the same within-sample contrast under a satellite-level clustered uncertainty treatment gives an odds ratio of 1.842 ($p = 0.02$).
- Control_{4C} dominated groups, where the median satellite spiral fraction is 0.67 for spiral BGGs and 0.50 for elliptical BGGs. The association between BGG morphology and satellite spiral fraction has a group-level odds ratio of 1.918 ($p < 10^{-4}$) in this sample; the same within-sample contrast under a satellite-level clustered uncertainty treatment gives an odds ratio of 1.918 ($p < 10^{-4}$).

In each case the group-level and satellite-level clustered treatments share the same point estimate by construction and differ only in the uncertainty model, which is why the odds ratios coincide.

4.4. Morphology versus Zheng–Shen class, magnitude gap, and BGG dominance

We next test whether the E/Sp morphology mix is associated with three group-level descriptors: the Zheng–Shen compact-group class, the first–second magnitude gap $\Delta m_{12} = M_{r,2} - M_{r,1}$, and the continuous BGG luminosity fraction $f_{L,\text{BGG}} = L_{\text{BGG}}/L_{\text{group}}$. These tests use only the existing Galaxy Zoo elliptical/smooth and spiral/features classes; uncertain morphologies are excluded from the binary fits. We run the tests separately for all galaxies, BGGs only,

Table 6. Elliptical/smooth and spiral/features counts by Zheng–Shen class for the CG₄ sample. Uncertain morphologies are excluded. Split systems have zero counts because they were removed by the existing non-split CG₄ sample definition.

Zheng–Shen class	All CG ₄ E/Sp	CG ₄ BGG E/Sp	CG ₄ sat. E/Sp
Split	0/0	0/0	0/0
Isolated	7/11	3/1	4/10
Predominant	41/22	11/5	30/17
Embedded	76/53	22/11	54/42

Table 7. Tests of the E-vs-Sp morphology mix against compact-group class, magnitude gap, and BGG luminosity fraction. The continuous columns report the available adjusted logistic model for $P(E)$; all-galaxy and satellite fits use group-clustered standard errors. Odds ratios are reported per magnitude for Δm_{12} and per 0.1 increase in luminosity fraction for $f_{L,BGG}$.

Subset	Sample	Test	Result
all galaxies	CG ₄	Class	$p = 0.137$
		Δm_{12}	OR 1.42, $p = 0.167$
		$f_{L,BGG}$	OR 1.29, $p = 0.080$
all galaxies	RG ₄	Class	not defined
		Δm_{12}	OR 1.33, $p = 0.220$
		$f_{L,BGG}$	OR 1.09, $p = 0.540$
BGGs only	CG ₄	Class	$p = 1.000$
		Δm_{12}	OR 1.77, $p = 0.426$
		$f_{L,BGG}$	OR 1.68, $p = 0.174$
BGGs only	RG ₄	Class	not defined
		Δm_{12}	OR 1.58, $p = 0.312$
		$f_{L,BGG}$	OR 1.21, $p = 0.520$
satellites only	CG ₄	Class	$p = 0.066$
		Δm_{12}	OR 1.28, $p = 0.346$
		$f_{L,BGG}$	OR 1.18, $p = 0.321$
satellites only	RG ₄	Class	not defined
		Δm_{12}	OR 1.41, $p = 0.342$
		$f_{L,BGG}$	OR 1.12, $p = 0.584$

and satellites only, so that any trend driven by the BGG itself is not folded into the satellite result. For satellites, $f_{L,BGG}$ mechanically includes the satellite luminosity in the group-luminosity denominator, so any satellite-level trend with $f_{L,BGG}$ is partly definitional; we therefore report the satellite models with a stellar-mass control.

The magnitude-gap and BGG-luminosity-fraction quantities are available for all 118 CG₄+RG₄ groups used in this test. The Zheng–Shen class is available only for compact groups. Split systems are absent from the current CG₄ sample because they are removed before the paper analysis, and no corresponding Zheng–Shen class is defined for the RG₄ catalogue used here. We therefore report the RG₄ class test as unavailable, while retaining RG₄ in the Δm_{12} and $f_{L,BGG}$ comparisons.

Overall, these tests provide little evidence that the E/Sp mix is driven by Zheng–Shen class, magnitude gap, or BGG luminosity fraction. The few marginal associations are therefore treated as descriptive diagnostics rather than as robust secondary trends.

For the Zheng–Shen compact-group class, no CG₄ association reaches the conventional 5% significance threshold. The closest case is the satellite-only test, which is treated as marginal and descriptive. Because the Zheng–Shen class is not defined for the RG₄ catalogue, we do not attempt an RG₄ class comparison.

For Δm_{12} , no statistically significant morphology trend is found in CG₄ or RG₄, whether the fit is run for all galaxies, BGGs only, or satellites only. The same conclusion holds for $f_{L,BGG}$: no fitted trend reaches $p < 0.05$. The CG₄–RG₄ interaction models detect no significant difference in the morphology–dominance relation for either Δm_{12} or $f_{L,BGG}$, across all galaxies, BGGs only, and satellites only. A class interaction is not defined because the Zheng–Shen compact-group class has no RG₄ counterpart in the present catalogue. Across the morphology–class, morphology–gap, morphology–luminosity-fraction, and interaction tests, no result remains significant after Benjamini–Hochberg FDR control.

4.5. Crossing time

The crossing-time diagnostic mainly separates systems by dynamical scale rather than by luminosity alone. Shorter t_{cross} systems have larger virial mass-to-light ratios and virial masses: the correlations with $\log(M_{VT}/L_r)$ and $\log(M_{VT})$ are $\rho_S = -0.39$ ($p < 10^{-4}$) and $\rho_S = -0.33$ ($p < 10^{-4}$), respectively, over 816 groups. By contrast, the relation with total group luminosity is formally detected but very weak ($\rho_S = 0.08$). We therefore read t_{cross} as a dynamical compactness indicator tied primarily to virial mass and mass-to-light ratio, with little independent leverage from L_{group} . Appendix Fig. D.9 shows the corresponding projected trend.

4.6. Optical colours

We derive the $(u-r)$, $(u-g)$, $(g-r)$ and $(r-i)$ colours from the matched SDSS photometry. The retained colour-analysis matches include 110 of 248 galaxies in CG₄, 931 of 2792 galaxies in Control_{4B}, 1368 of 2816 galaxies in Control_{4C}, 102 of 224 galaxies in RG₄. This stricter subset differs from the availability audit in Fig. D.24: the figure’s colour row only requires the four derived SDSS colour columns to be present in the final catalogue, giving 217 of 248 CG₄ galaxies, whereas the colour analysis here also requires successful matched-photometry retention and the covariates used below. Stellar mass is a confounding variable in colour comparisons (Alpaslan et al. 2015); we therefore model each colour jointly with $\log(M_\star/M_\odot)$ rather than comparing unadjusted colour distributions.

The colour-analysis subset is not representative of the full galaxy catalogues: matched galaxies are systematically less massive, more actively star-forming, and more frequently satellites than unmatched galaxies. The fractions retained in this stricter colour-analysis subset are 44.4% in CG₄, 33.3% in Control_{4B}, 48.6% in Control_{4C}, 45.5% in RG₄. The colour analysis is therefore useful as a secondary diagnostic, but it cannot carry the main interpretation by itself.

The raw catalogue colour–mass fits indicate that CG₄ does not simply follow the same colour–mass relation as every comparison sample: common slopes are rejected in all four colours, with the significant directional slope differences concentrated in the bluer colours and dependent on the adopted comparison catalogue. In the satellite-only comparison, the fitted offsets and slopes likewise depend on the control definition. These tests motivate the robustness analysis rather than establishing a stand-alone compact-group colour effect.

We therefore refit the satellite colours with cluster-robust standard errors, using catalogue-qualified group identifiers. In the pooled comparison adjusted only for stellar mass and redshift, none of the four CG₄ coefficients is significantly negative after Holm correction. Adding morphology and sSFR class does not reveal a significant negative coefficient. However, these adjusted coefficients are control-sample dependent, and they do not persist within the sSFR or morphology splits. The data therefore do not localize the colour effect to the star-forming spiral population expected for a simple interaction-triggered star-formation scenario.

Residual colour trends with projected BGG-centric distance are consistent with stronger processing near the group centre and a less processed outer population, but these trends use the same biased colour subset and are treated as exploratory. The group-level BGG–satellite colour concordance is similarly secondary: redder BGGs tend to have redder mean satellite populations in the combined group sample, but the CG₄ slope is not a robustly distinct population-level signature. Detailed colour–mass, satellite, and radial diagnostics are shown in Appendix Figs. D.10–D.12. Figure 4 summarizes the model and control-sample dependence that motivates our interpretation: the present data do not establish a robust global blue or red offset for CG₄ satellites.

5. Robustness: what drives the compact-group differences?

The previous sections establish that CG₄ galaxies differ from the control catalogues in their population mix, especially in morphology and in the star-forming fraction of satellites. We now ask whether these differences survive after controlling for stellar mass, rank and available group-scale quantities, and whether they are better interpreted as compact-group-specific evolution, preprocessing in dense halo cores, or catalogue-selection effects.

5.1. Per-control adjusted contrasts (primary)

The three control samples answer different questions, so our primary inference fits CG₄ against each control *separately*: against Control_{4B} (is the CG₄ population special compared with the luminous population of richer ordinary groups?), against Control_{4C} (compared with BGG-centred projected cores?), and against RG₄ (compared with true four-member ordinary groups?). Each contrast fits the same family of adjusted binomial models (stellar mass, redshift, rank, group luminosity, and velocity dispersion where sufficiently complete), with standard errors clustered by *physical* group: the Lim group for controls, and for CG₄ systems their host Lim group where one exists, so that the same physical system never enters as more than one cluster. Holm correction is applied within each contrast across its model family.

Against Control_{4B}, the smooth/elliptical odds ratio is 2.14 (95% CI [1.58, 2.90]; Holm-corrected $p < 10^{-4}$), and the quenched odds ratio is 1.80 (Holm-corrected $p = 0.003$).

Against Control_{4C}, the smooth/elliptical odds ratio is 1.30 (95% CI [0.98, 1.73]; Holm-corrected $p = 0.443$), and the quenched odds ratio is 0.91 (Holm-corrected $p = 1.000$).

Against RG₄, the smooth/elliptical odds ratio is 2.81 (95% CI [1.79, 4.38]; Holm-corrected $p < 10^{-4}$), and the quenched odds ratio is 1.40 (Holm-corrected $p = 0.476$).

The asymmetry between the contrasts is itself informative: the CG₄ morphology excess is strong against the luminosity-selected cores of richer groups and against true four-member groups, but weak and non-significant against the BGG-centred *projected* cores of ordinary groups, which are the control definition that most closely mimics a compact projected configuration. This pattern anticipates the local projected-density interpretation of Sect. 5.11.

5.2. Pooled adjusted models (secondary)

As a compact summary across the heterogeneous control definitions we also fit binomial models to the pooled catalogue. Because the control samples overlap heavily (all RG₄ galaxies are also Control_{4B} members, and Control_{4B} and Control_{4C} share their cores), the pooled control side is first deduplicated by SDSS objid — one row per physical galaxy, unweighted, with every source label recorded — and standard errors are clustered by physical Lim group. The common adjustment set includes stellar mass, redshift, satellite/BGG rank, group luminosity and velocity dispersion when sufficiently complete. This pooled family is read as a secondary summary; the per-control contrasts above are primary.

For quenched status, the CG₄ odds ratio is 1.08, with 95% confidence interval [0.80, 1.44] and Holm-corrected $p = 1.000$.

For quenched satellite status, the CG₄ odds ratio is 1.17, with 95% confidence interval [0.86, 1.58] and Holm-corrected $p = 1.000$.

For star-forming satellite status, the CG₄ odds ratio is 0.86, with 95% confidence interval [0.63, 1.16] and Holm-corrected $p = 1.000$.

For elliptical morphology, the CG₄ odds ratio is 1.50, with 95% confidence interval [1.13, 1.99] and Holm-corrected $p = 0.032$.

For elliptical satellite morphology, the CG₄ odds ratio is 1.71, with 95% confidence interval [1.24, 2.34] and Holm-corrected $p = 0.007$.

For elliptical BGG morphology, the CG₄ odds ratio is 0.77, with 95% confidence interval [0.39, 1.53] and Holm-corrected $p = 1.000$.

For spiral morphology, the CG₄ odds ratio is 0.67, with 95% confidence interval [0.50, 0.89] and Holm-corrected $p = 0.032$.

For spiral satellite morphology, the CG₄ odds ratio is 0.59, with 95% confidence interval [0.43, 0.80] and Holm-corrected $p = 0.007$.

Compact-group membership therefore remains independently associated with morphology after the available adjustments: CG₄ galaxies have a higher probability of being elliptical and a lower probability of being spiral. In contrast, the adjusted quenched and star-forming satellite coefficients are weaker and do not provide evidence for an instantaneous star-formation difference that remains significant after correction.

The adjusted morphology signal is primarily carried by satellites rather than BGGs: the satellite-only models give a smooth/elliptical odds ratio of 1.71 and a spiral/features odds ratio of 0.59, whereas the BGG smooth/elliptical co-

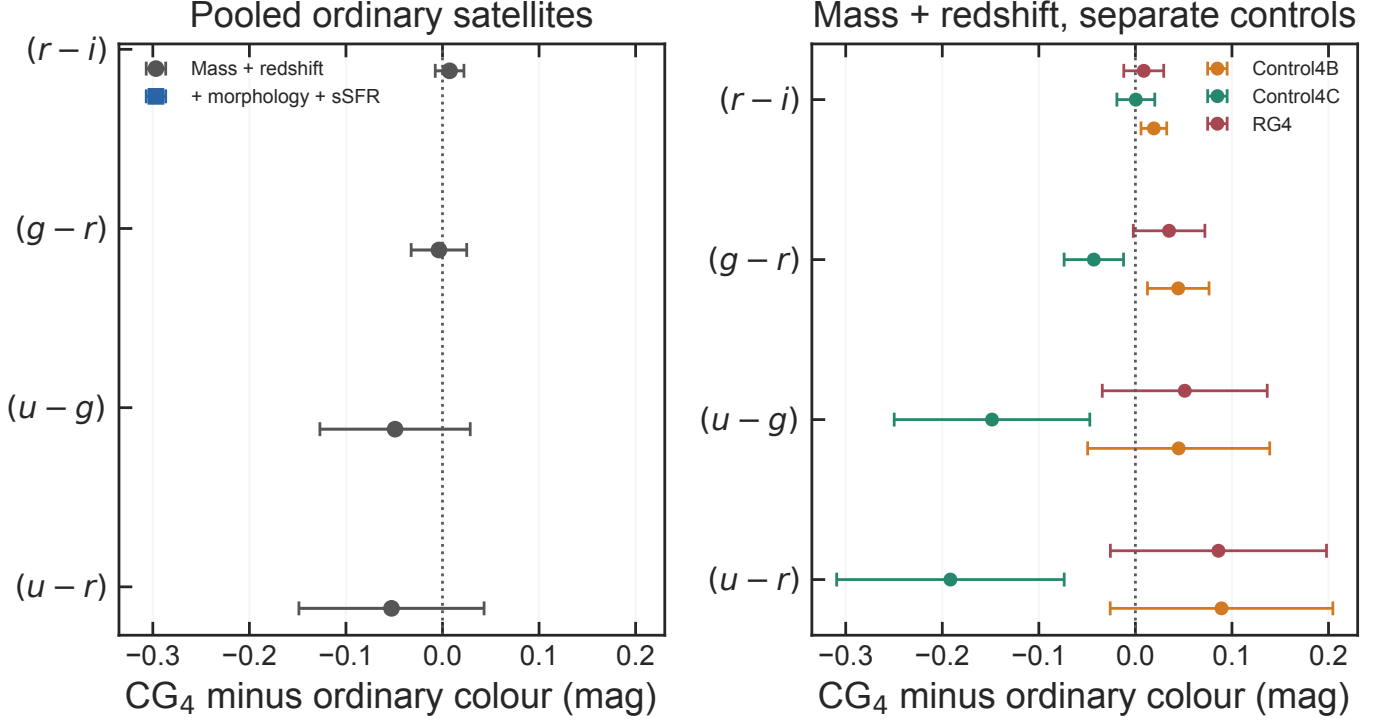


Fig. 4. Robustness of the satellite colour coefficients. Left: pooled ordinary-group comparison before and after controlling for morphology and sSFR class. Right: mass- and redshift-adjusted comparisons against each control catalogue separately. Points show the CG₄ minus ordinary coefficient and bars show 95% confidence intervals; negative values indicate bluer CG₄ satellites.

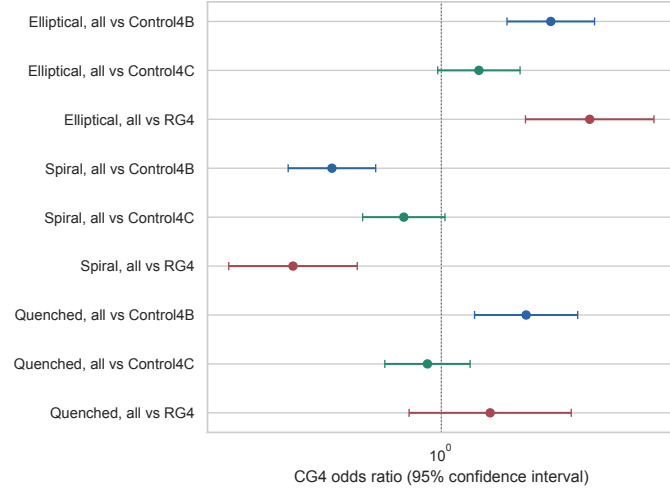


Fig. 5. Adjusted CG₄ odds ratios from the three separate per-control contrasts (colour-coded by control sample) for the all-member elliptical, spiral and quenched outcomes. Bars show 95% confidence intervals; the vertical line marks equal odds.

efficient is not significant after adjustment (OR 0.77; Holm-corrected $p = 1.000$).

5.3. Morphology robustness to projected crowding

Because Galaxy Zoo morphology is image-based, the CG₄ smooth/elliptical excess must be checked against projected crowding and deblending. We therefore repeat the morphology comparison after excluding galaxies whose nearest projected neighbour within the catalogue group lies within

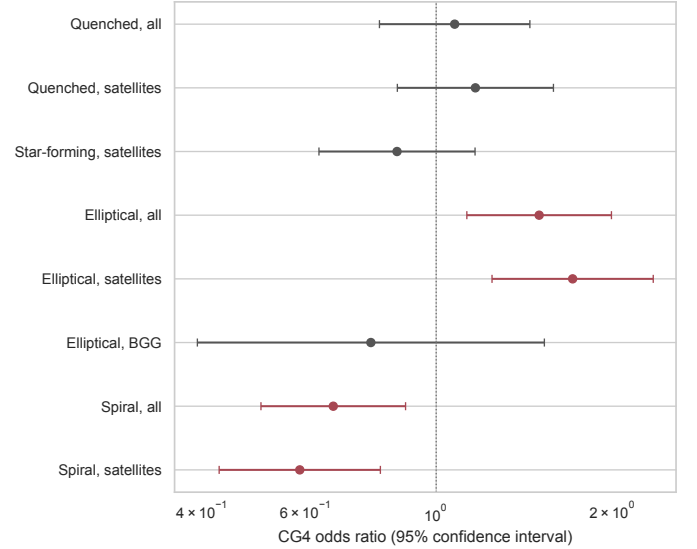


Fig. 6. Adjusted CG₄ odds ratios for star-formation and morphology diagnostics, including all-galaxy, satellite-only, and BGG-only morphology rows. Bars show 95% confidence intervals; the vertical line marks equal odds.

55 arcsec. The retained samples contain 200 CG₄ galaxies and 2455 Control_{4C} galaxies. After this exclusion, the CG₄ smooth/elliptical fraction is 52.5%, compared with 41.1% in Control_{4C}; the CG₄–Control_{4C} exact-test result remains significant ($p = 0.002$). The CG₄ smooth fraction rises relative to the raw full-sample value in Table 2, rather than falling after the closest projected pairs are removed. This argues against the simplest interpretation that the CG₄

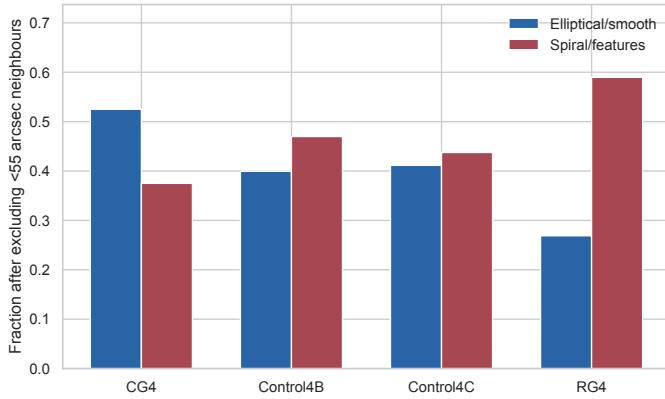


Fig. 7. Galaxy Zoo morphology fractions after excluding galaxies with a nearest projected neighbour within 55 arcsec. The CG₄ smooth/elliptical excess persists after this closest-neighbour exclusion.

smooth excess is produced solely by crowding in the closest pairs.

The complementary close-neighbour-flag model reaches the same qualitative conclusion. After adjusting for the standard covariates and a < 55 -arcsec neighbour flag, the CG₄ smooth/elliptical odds ratio is 1.52 (95% CI [1.13, 2.04]; $p = 0.006$). The close-neighbour flag is itself associated with smooth morphology (OR 2.07; $p < 10^{-4}$), so this test does not prove that all Galaxy Zoo classifications are immune to crowding. It does rule out the simplest closest-pair artefact as the sole origin of the morphology result. Figure 7 shows the corresponding post-exclusion morphology fractions.

5.4. Morphology robustness to the classification threshold

The adopted Galaxy Zoo classification (debiased vote fraction > 0.5) is one of several defensible cuts, so we repeat the adjusted all-member smooth/elliptical model on the duplicated pooled sample at thresholds of 0.4, 0.5, 0.6 and 0.8. The CG₄ odds ratio varies from 1.46 to 1.98 across this range and never changes sign, so the morphology contrast is not tied to the adopted threshold (the unclassified fraction grows from 13% to 50% over the sweep). A threshold-free check models the debiased elliptical vote fraction p_E itself: the adjusted CG₄ offset is 0.070 (95% CI [0.027, 0.112]; $p = 0.001$).

A structural cross-check independent of Galaxy Zoo uses the Simard et al. (2011) pure-Sérsic index (early type: $n_g > 2.5$; 77% coverage): the adjusted CG₄ odds ratio is 1.42 ($p = 0.018$), consistent in direction with the vote-fraction results, subject to the differential Simard completeness discussed in Sect. 5.12.

5.5. Matched-control comparison

We matched 234 of the 248 available CG₄ galaxies one-to-one to 234 ordinary-group galaxies without replacement, requiring common propensity-score support, a 0.2-standard-deviation caliper and exact rank strata. The remaining 14 CG₄ galaxies were excluded because they lay outside the common propensity-score support or exceeded the adopted caliper. The control pool is first deduplicated by SDSS objid (5832 control rows collapse to 3983 unique galaxies), and

two hard constraints are enforced: no control may share an objid with a CG₄ galaxy, and no control galaxy is used more than once. By kept label, the matched controls comprise 141 Control4B, 77 Control4C, 16 RG4; by physical provenance, 16 of the 234 matched controls are physically RG₄ galaxies (which also appear in Control4B through the sample overlap), and the full per-galaxy provenance is recorded in the released `matched_control_provenance.csv`. The propensity model uses $\log M_*$, redshift, rank, $\log L_{\text{group}}$, and σ_v . Projected distance is retained as a phase-space and interaction diagnostic rather than matched away because it partly defines compactness and has limited overlap. The largest absolute standardized mean difference changed from 0.24 before matching to 0.11 afterwards. The residual imbalance is carried by the group-luminosity covariate ($\log L_{\text{group}}$); it lies slightly above the conventional 0.1 threshold, which is why we read the matched contrasts together with the adjusted models rather than in isolation.

Matched differences below are quoted with group-blocked bootstrap intervals: pairs are resampled by the treated galaxy's compact group (never galaxy by galaxy), with $B = 9999$ resamples and add-one empirical p-values, so the smallest reportable p-value is $2/(B + 1)$.

Group-level matched contrast. Because the four galaxies of a compact group are not independent, the cleanest matched estimand is at the *group* level: for each group we count its smooth/elliptical satellites ($N_{\text{smooth,sat}} \in \{0, 1, 2, 3\}$) and match CG₄ groups one-to-one to control groups (one quartet per physical Lim group) on redshift, BGG stellar mass, total quartet luminosity, and velocity dispersion. Over 54 matched group pairs, the CG₄-minus-control difference in the smooth-satellite fraction is 0.160 (95% bootstrap interval [0.019, 0.299]; $p = 0.027$, $B = 9999$). The galaxy-level contrasts below are read as secondary checks of this group-level result.

The matched CG₄-minus-control difference in quenched fraction is -0.022 , with 95% bootstrap interval $[-0.100, 0.055]$ and Holm-corrected $p = 1.000$.

After matching, this does not provide evidence for an enhanced quenched fraction in CG₄ that remains significant after correction.

The corresponding CG₄-minus-control difference in star-forming fraction is 0.022, with 95% bootstrap interval $[-0.055, 0.100]$ and Holm-corrected $p = 1.000$.

The matched CG₄-minus-control difference in elliptical fraction is 0.087, with 95% bootstrap interval $[-0.005, 0.179]$ and Holm-corrected $p = 0.361$.

The matched CG₄-minus-control difference in spiral fraction is -0.087 , with 95% bootstrap interval $[-0.179, 0.005]$ and Holm-corrected $p = 0.361$.

Among matched star-forming galaxies, the residual-sSFR difference is 0.074, with 95% bootstrap interval $[-0.075, 0.226]$ and $p = 0.332$.

The matched-outcome Holm correction is intentionally conservative: quenched/star-forming and elliptical/spiral diagnostics are retained in the same family even though the audit finds that they are exact complements on their complete-case subsets. Using a non-redundant family would not weaken the morphology conclusion.

The main interpretation does not rely on the exact GMM division of the sSFR plane. Repeating the key satellite comparison with a fixed threshold, $\log_{10}(\text{sSFR}/\text{yr}^{-1}) =$

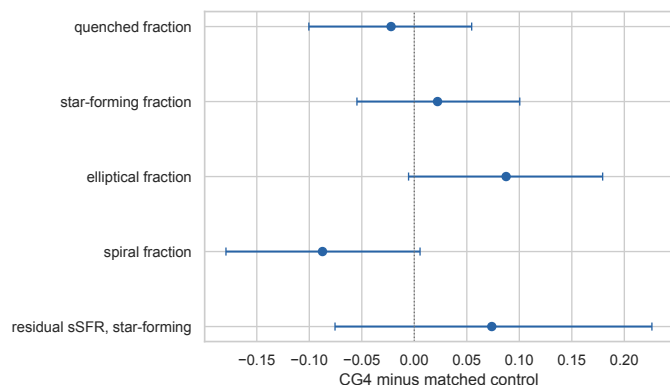


Fig. 8. CG₄-minus-control effects after one-to-one matching. Bars show 95% bootstrap confidence intervals.

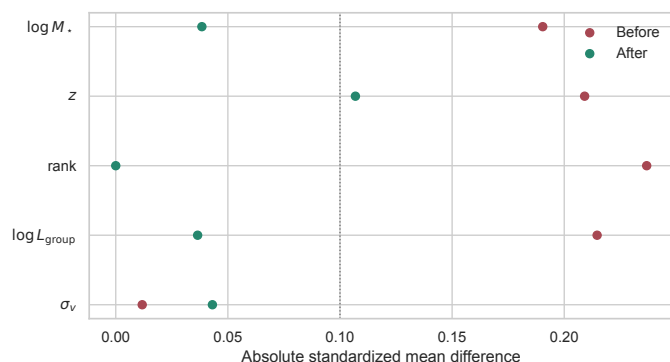


Fig. 9. Absolute standardized mean differences before and after matching.

–11.0, gives CG₄ and RG₄ satellite star-forming fractions of 41.4% and 60.2%, respectively, a CG₄–RG₄ difference of –18.9 percentage points ($p = 5.3 \times 10^{-4}$). The qualitative hierarchy is unchanged: the morphology result is independent of the sSFR threshold, whereas the quenched/star-forming contrast remains more sensitive to modelling choices.

The matched comparison is therefore consistent with the adjusted models: the most robust compact-group signal is morphological, while the quenched and star-forming-fraction signals are more model-dependent.

5.6. Compact-group members versus other members of the same host group

For the Embedded and Predominant CG₄ systems, whose quartets live inside richer Lim parent groups, the sharpest test of “compact subconfiguration versus shared host environment” compares the CG₄ member galaxies with the *non-CG₄ members of the same host group*: every host-level confounder (halo mass, richness, redshift, large-scale environment) cancels by construction. Over 54 host groups (958 member galaxies, of which 224 belong to a CG₄), we model smooth/elliptical morphology and quenched status as functions of CG₄ membership at fixed stellar mass, host luminosity rank, and projected host-centric radius, clustering by host group.

The within-host smooth/elliptical odds ratio for CG₄ membership is 1.36 (95% CI [0.92, 2.00]; Holm-corrected $p = 0.250$), and the within-host quenched odds ratio is 0.75 (Holm-corrected $p = 0.250$).

At fixed stellar mass, rank, and host-centric radius, membership in the compact subconfiguration therefore adds no detectable morphology excess *within* a shared host. This is consistent with the per-control asymmetry of Sect. 5.1: the CG₄ excess appears against galaxies of *other* groups, not against co-members of the same host, pointing to position within the host (its dense projected core) rather than compact-group membership per se.

This analysis is new relative to the rest of the paper and can be disabled wholesale through a configuration toggle.

5.7. Satellite segregation around the brightest group galaxy

The previous sections show global differences between CG₄ and RG₄ satellites. We now ask whether these differences are concentrated near the BGG, as expected for accelerated evolution in the dense inner group, or whether they persist across the satellite population. The analysis uses 174 CG₄ and 166 RG₄ satellites, excludes rank-1 galaxies, ranks satellites by projected BGG-centric distance, and measures quenched and early-type fractions with group-cluster bootstrap uncertainties. When available, we also use $|\Delta v_{\text{BGG}}|/\sigma_v$, with $\Delta v_{\text{BGG}} = c(z_{\text{gal}} - z_{\text{BGG}})/(1 + z_{\text{group}})$, as a projected phase-space diagnostic. Similar projected phase-space coordinates are often used as observational proxies for satellite infall state or quenching time, but only statistically (Mahajan et al. 2011; Oman & Hudson 2016; Wetzel et al. 2013).

In the innermost satellite-distance bin, the quenched fractions are 68.3% for CG₄ and 48.2% for RG₄, a CG₄–RG₄ difference of 20.1 percentage points. The corresponding early-type fractions are 64.7% and 35.6%, with a difference of 29.2 percentage points.

The quenched-fraction contrast is similar between the inner and outer distance ranks, so the data do not isolate the CG₄ offset to the immediate BGG environment.

After adjusting for stellar mass, redshift, distance bin, and available group-scale controls, the quenched-status model gives a CG₄ odds ratio of 1.18 (95% CI 0.43–3.24; $p = 0.742$).

The analogous early-type model gives a CG₄ odds ratio of 2.42 ($p = 0.078$).

A nearest-neighbour mass–redshift matched check uses 126 CG₄–RG₄ satellite pairs. The matched quenched-fraction difference is 9.5 percentage points, and the matched early-type difference is 18.7 percentage points.

Projected phase-space coordinates should not be read as orbital reconstructions for individual galaxies. In compact groups the member counts are small, velocity dispersions are noisy, and projection mixes recently accreted and long-resident satellites. We therefore treat these bins as an observational diagnostic of where the CG₄–RG₄ population contrast appears, rather than as a direct dynamical clock.

5.8. Magnitude gaps and fossil-like assembly

We define $\Delta m_{12} = M_{r,2} - M_{r,1}$ and $\Delta m_{14} = M_{r,4} - M_{r,1}$, so that a more dominant BGG has a positive, larger gap.

For Δm_{12} , the CG₄ and control medians are 1.17 and 1.10 mag, respectively (Holm-corrected $p = 0.824$).

For Δm_{14} , the CG₄ and control medians are 2.56 and 2.59 mag, respectively (Holm-corrected $p = 0.824$).

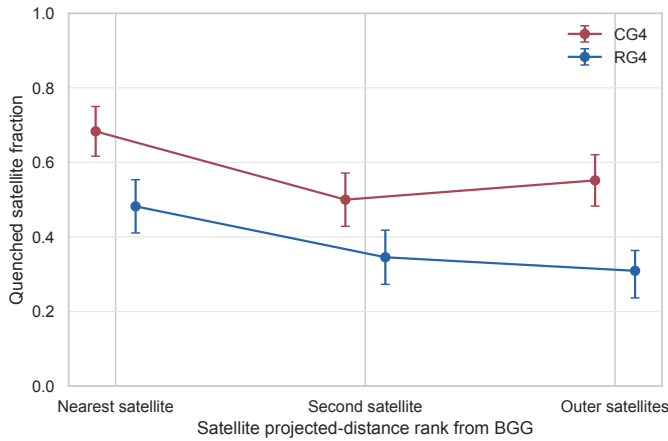


Fig. 10. Quenched satellite fraction as a function of projected-distance rank from the BGG. Points show CG₄ and RG₄ fractions; bars show group-cluster bootstrap 16th–84th percentile intervals.

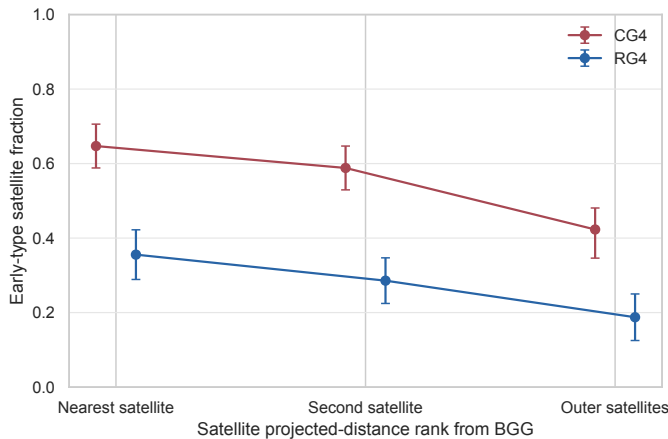


Fig. 11. Early-type satellite fraction as a function of projected-distance rank from the BGG. Because the catalogue separates ellipticals, spirals, and uncertain morphologies but not S0 galaxies, early type is equivalent to elliptical in this diagnostic.

The compact-group morphology signal is therefore not accompanied by a significant excess in these simple fossil-like magnitude-gap indicators.

The correlation between Δm_{12} and quenched satellite fraction is $\rho_S = -0.14$ (Holm-corrected $p < 10^{-4}$).

The supporting magnitude-gap distributions are shown in Appendix Figs. D.20 and D.21.

5.9. Recently quenched candidates

900 The catalogues do not contain both D_n4000 and $H\delta_A$, so a post-starburst classification is not possible. We therefore perform only a limited $H\alpha$ -equivalent-width comparison, using the SDSS convention in which negative equivalent width denotes emission. We classify strong $H\alpha$ emission using $H\alpha \text{ EW} \leq -3 \text{ \AA}$.

The strong-emission fraction is 32.3% in CG₄, 41.0% in Control_{4B}, 44.2% in Control_{4C}, 56.9% in RG₄.

Relative to Control_{4B}, the CG₄ strong-emission fraction differs by -0.087 (Holm-corrected $p = 0.012$).

900 Relative to Control_{4C}, the CG₄ strong-emission fraction differs by -0.119 (Holm-corrected $p = 0.001$).

Relative to RG₄, the CG₄ strong-emission fraction differs by -0.246 (Holm-corrected $p < 10^{-4}$).

These limited $H\alpha$ results indicate that CG₄ galaxies have a lower strong-emission fraction than in each control sample in the current catalogue, but they do not provide a direct post-starburst or recently-quenched classification.

The $H\alpha$ equivalent-width distributions are shown in Appendix Fig. D.22.

5.10. Emission-line and AGN-like populations

910 The complementary emission-line analysis classifies BPT star-forming, composite, and AGN-like populations for galaxies with the required diagnostic line ratios: composite galaxies lie between the Kauffmann et al. (2003a) and Kewley et al. (2001) demarcations in the [NII] BPT plane, and AGN-like galaxies lie above the Kewley et al. (2001) line; galaxies with a pre-existing AGN flag but no BPT line ratios are also counted as AGN-like. BPT-unclassified galaxies are excluded from the AGN-like fraction denominator rather than treated as confirmed non-AGN. Among BPT-classified CG₄ galaxies, the AGN-like fraction is 38.0%.

After mass and environment adjustment, the CG₄ AGN-like odds ratio is 1.14 ($p = 0.447$).

Thus, AGN-like activity does not provide a robust independent compact-group discriminator in this analysis.

The AGN-like fractions are shown in Appendix Fig. D.23.

5.11. Pairwise tidal index

930 The pairwise analysis reconstructs projected separations and velocity differences for 6080 galaxies and refits the adjusted models with and without the pairwise tidal index $\sum_j M_{\star,j}/R_{ij}^3$ (in $M_\odot \text{ kpc}^{-3}$). The two model variants estimate different quantities, and we state both estimands explicitly. The model without the index estimates the total association between compact-group membership and the outcome at fixed stellar mass, redshift, rank, and group-scale covariates. The model with the index estimates the association at fixed projected local density. Because the index is built from R^{-3} -weighted projected separations, it is mathematically entangled with the compact-group selection itself (compact groups are selected to have small projected separations); conditioning on it therefore partially conditions on the exposure. A reduction of the CG₄ coefficient when the index is added is thus conditional attenuation, not mediation: it does not show that local density accounts for the morphology contrast, and it cannot, because the causal ordering of selection, density, and morphology is not identified by projected snapshots. The baseline models in this subsection are refit on the pairwise-analysis complete-case sample, so their coefficients need not be numerically identical to the corresponding coefficients in Sect. 5.2. Because R_{ij} is projected, the term is a local projected-density and immediate-neighbour proxy rather than a direct tidal-history measurement.

950 For quenched status, the baseline CG₄ odds ratio is 1.17 ($p = 0.291$), while the model including the tidal index gives

a CG₄ odds ratio of 0.77 ($p = 0.106$). The tidal-index term itself has odds ratio 1.68 ($p < 10^{-4}$).

For elliptical morphology, the baseline CG₄ odds ratio is 1.64 ($p = 4.4 \times 10^{-4}$), whereas the model including the tidal index gives a CG₄ odds ratio of 1.13 ($p = 0.421$). This baseline is the pairwise complete-case refit, not the full adjusted model in Sect. 5.2. The tidal-index term has odds ratio 1.58 ($p < 10^{-4}$). The projected tidal-density proxy therefore *attenuates* the CG₄ coefficient, indicating that the morphology contrast is concentrated in the most extreme local projected configurations; given the selection entanglement described above, this conditional attenuation must not be read as the index accounting for the effect, and the result remains an exploratory projected-pair diagnostic.

5.12. Galaxy sizes at fixed stellar mass

We now test whether CG₄ galaxies differ in size at fixed stellar mass, using the seeing-corrected Simard half-light radii as the primary measure and the Petrosian radii as the model-independent cross-check (Sect. 2.4). The Simard measure resolves 77.4% of the CG₄ galaxies and 72.2% of the pooled control galaxies, while the Petrosian radius is essentially complete in every sample (Appendix Fig. D.13). Because the CG₄-control difference in Simard completeness exceeds five percentage points, every Simard-based coefficient below carries a differential-completeness caveat and is read together with the Petrosian rerun, which does not share this incompleteness. The descriptive mass-size relations and the per-sample sizes predicted at $\log(M_\star/M_\odot) = 10.3$ are shown in Appendix Fig. D.14.

For satellite galaxy size, the CG₄ offset at fixed stellar mass, redshift, and available group-scale covariates is -0.000 dex (-0.1%), with 95% confidence interval $[-0.030, 0.030]$ and Holm-corrected $p = 1.000$, over 3878 satellites in 1482 groups.

The all-galaxy model gives 0.000 dex (95% CI $[-0.026, 0.027]$; Holm-corrected $p = 1.000$), and the BGG-only model gives 0.008 dex (Holm-corrected $p = 1.000$).

No coefficient in this primary family remains significant after Holm correction, so the pooled adjusted models do not establish a CG₄ size offset at fixed stellar mass.

The per-control versions of the mass- and redshift-adjusted fit are descriptive and shown in Appendix Fig. D.15; the fitted CG₄ coefficient is -0.035 dex against Control_{4B}, 0.027 dex against Control_{4C}, -0.006 dex against RG₄ (raw p-values with Benjamini-Hochberg control inside this figure family). The sign and significance of the CG₄ coefficient depend on the adopted control, so we do not interpret any single per-control contrast on its own.

The one-to-one matched comparison re-derives the same 234 propensity pairs as the matched-control analysis, with a separate Holm family for the three size outcomes so that the published matched-outcome family is untouched. On the 160 pairs in which both members have valid Simard sizes, the mean CG₄-minus-control difference in $\log_{10} R_{\text{chl},r}$ is 0.027 dex (95% bootstrap interval $[-0.013, 0.065]$; Holm-corrected $p = 0.556$). The corresponding Petrosian difference is 0.005 dex (Holm-corrected $p = 1.000$), and the matched concentration difference is 0.005 (Holm-corrected $p = 1.000$).

The crowding checks mirror Sect. 5.3: excluding galaxies with a projected neighbour within 55 arcsec leaves a satellite coefficient of -0.001 dex ($p = 0.942$), and adding

the close-neighbour flag as a covariate gives 0.001 dex ($p = 0.972$).

The Petrosian rerun, with the field seeing as an additional standardized covariate, gives a satellite coefficient of -0.015 dex (Holm-corrected $p = 0.413$) and an all-galaxy coefficient of -0.013 dex (Holm-corrected $p = 0.413$).

The per-galaxy difference between the two measures, $d = \log R_{\text{chl},r} - \log R_{50,r}$, averages 0.048 dex, and is larger for elliptical/smooth galaxies (0.068 dex) than for spiral/features galaxies (0.038 dex), as expected if the Petrosian aperture preferentially truncates concentrated profiles. Its rank correlation with the nearest-neighbour separation is $\rho_S = -0.000$ ($p = 0.984$), so residual blending does not drive a strong measure-dependent size systematic (Appendix Fig. D.16).

Adding the pairwise projected tidal index of Sect. 5.11 to the all-galaxy size model changes the CG₄ coefficient from 0.000 dex to 0.027 dex on the pairwise complete-case sample; with a near-null baseline coefficient, the attenuation diagnostic used for morphology is not informative here.

The radial diagnostic is exploratory: mass- and redshift-adjusted satellite size residuals correlate with projected BGG-centric distance with $\rho_S = 0.18$ ($p = 0.023$) in CG₄ and $\rho_S = 0.19$ ($p < 10^{-4}$) in the pooled controls (Appendix Fig. D.18). A more negative inner-region residual would be the tidal-truncation expectation; the observed trends are similar in CG₄ and the controls, so the data do not isolate a CG₄-specific inner-region size suppression.

The concentration index $C = R_{90,r}/R_{50,r}$ provides a model-independent structural proxy: the adjusted satellite coefficient is 0.065 (Holm-corrected $p = 0.413$), so CG₄ membership does not significantly shift the concentration index at fixed mass.

Within morphology classes, the satellite-only fits give 0.035 dex for elliptical/smooth satellites (Holm-corrected $p = 0.204$) and 0.000 dex for spiral/features satellites (Holm-corrected $p = 0.984$), and the CG₄×morphology interaction is 0.035 dex ($p = 0.299$). These strata are secondary diagnostics; they test whether any size offset is independent information beyond the morphology signal rather than a restatement of it.

5.13. Selection diagnostics

The fractions with complete measurements for the major derived quantities are shown in Appendix Fig. D.24. The colour-matched versus unmatched comparisons quantify shifts in stellar mass, redshift, rank, star-formation class and morphology.

The median nearest-neighbour angular separation is 100.9 arcsec in CG₄ and 210.5 arcsec in the controls; the fractions below the 55-arcsec SDSS fibre-collision scale are 19.4% and 9.2% , respectively.

Under the availability definitions shown in Fig. D.24, no major availability difference meets both criteria of corrected significance and a difference exceeding 10 percentage points.

The group-scale availability row is based on the group covariates available for this catalogue: radius scale, velocity dispersion, group luminosity, and BGG luminosity dominance. A harmonized group-mass estimate is not available in these tables, so models that request it omit that covariate.

The colour-selection mass audit is shown in Appendix Fig. D.25.

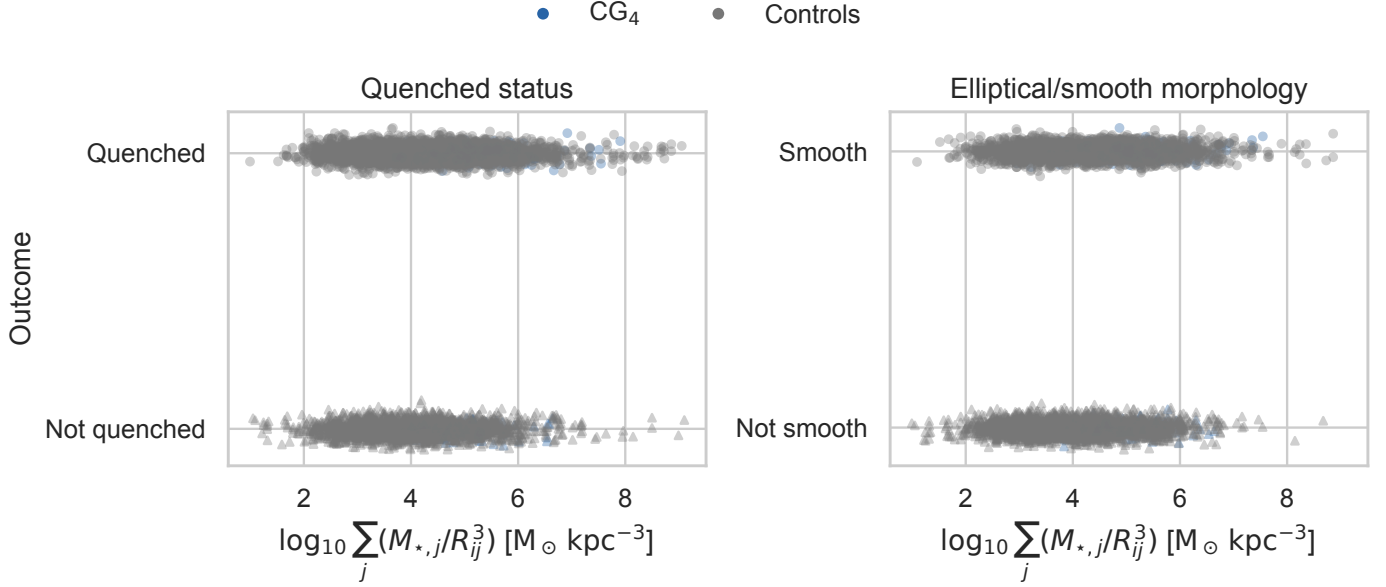


Fig. 12. Quenched status and elliptical/smooth morphology as functions of the reconstructed pairwise tidal index. Colours distinguish CG₄ from control galaxies.

Table 8. Result hierarchy. Baseline tests describe where CG₄ differs from the controls; the main interpretation is based on diagnostics that remain after adjusted or matched comparisons.

Diagnostic	Baseline CG ₄ signal	Survives adjusted/ matched analysis?	Interpretation
Elliptical/smooth fraction	Enhanced in CG ₄	Yes	Robust accumulated morphology signal.
Spiral/features fraction	Reduced in CG ₄	Yes	Reduced late-type vote-fraction population.
Galaxy Zoo crowding check	Smooth excess persists after close-neighbour exclusion	Yes, as a limited robustness check	Morphology result not solely produced by the closest projected pairs.
Satellite star-forming fraction	Reduced, especially versus RG ₄	Weak or borderline	Partly explained by mass, rank, environment, or preprocessing.
Star-forming main-sequence residual	Weak and control-dependent	No robust offset	No strong instantaneous SFR enhancement or suppression among remaining star-forming galaxies.
Satellite colours	Colour-slope and residual hints	Control-sensitive	Exploratory; not a simple uniform reddening or blueing of CG ₄ satellites.
AGN-like fraction	No robust independent signal	No	Not an AGN-driven explanation.
Magnitude gaps	No significant excess	No	Not fossil-like under the simple gap diagnostics used here.
Pairwise tidal index	Local projected density proxy is informative	Reframes much of the morphology coefficient	Local projected density is linked to the morphology signal.
Galaxy size at fixed mass	Hints of smaller CG ₄ sizes	No	No compact-group size effect at fixed stellar mass.
Concentration index	$R_{90,r}/R_{50,r}$ structural proxy now measured	No	No independent concentration signal at fixed mass.

6. Discussion: drivers of structural evolution in compact groups

6.1. Local projected tidal density and morphology signal

The most robust residual difference between CG₄ and the regular-group controls is morphological. CG₄ galaxies are

more likely to be classified as elliptical/smooth and less likely to be classified as spiral/features. In the per-control adjusted models the excess is strong against Control_{4B} and RG₄ but not against Control_{4C}, and it is recovered at the group level in the matched comparison (higher smooth-satellite fraction in matched CG₄ groups), while the galaxy-

level matched contrast is directionally consistent but not significant once the four galaxies of a group are resampled together. The within-host comparison of Sect. 5.6 finds no residual excess of CG₄ members over other members of the same host. The result hierarchy therefore points to accumulated structural transformation in dense projected cores more strongly than to a present-day star-formation offset or to compact-group membership as such.

The pairwise tidal-index experiment strengthens this interpretation while also narrowing it. For elliptical/smooth morphology, the pairwise complete-case baseline CG₄ odds ratio is 1.64 ($p = 4.4 \times 10^{-4}$), so it is not expected to match exactly the full adjusted-model odds ratio in Sect. 5.2. After adding the projected pairwise tidal-index proxy, the CG₄ odds ratio decreases to 1.13 ($p = 0.421$), while the tidal-index term itself has odds ratio 1.58 ($p < 10^{-4}$). This behaviour is expected if compact groups are selecting galaxies in locally dense projected configurations where repeated close companions, rather than the catalogue label alone, are linked to the smooth/early-type-like population.

This proxy uses projected separations, so it may be inflated by line-of-sight alignments and is partly entangled with compact-group selection itself: compact groups are selected to be compact in projection. We therefore read the tidal-index result as a continuous local projected-density or immediate-neighbour proxy, not as a direct time-dependent tidal-field measurement. The Control_{4C} comparison makes the test deliberately stringent, because Control_{4C} is also selected as a projected compact core around a BGG. The persistence of a CG₄–Control_{4C} morphology contrast in the closest-neighbour exclusion test shows that the CG₄ label is not reduced to the simplest crowding artefact. At the same time, the tidal-index model indicates that a more continuous projected-density proxy absorbs much of the CG₄ coefficient. We therefore interpret the residual CG₄–Control_{4C} contrast as consistent with CG₄ selecting a more extreme part of the local-density distribution, rather than as proof that compact groups define a separate causal channel.

6.2. Galaxy sizes and comparison with earlier compact-group size studies

Coenda et al. (2012) compared galaxies in the McConnachie et al. (2009) compact groups with loose-group and field samples using SDSS Petrosian half-light radii and found compact-group galaxies to be smaller at fixed luminosity, with the clearest offset for early types relative to the field. Their assessment rested on approximately 1σ comparisons of fitted size–luminosity relations, without a formal confidence level on the size difference itself. The present analysis re-poses that question with a different control design – the non-split HMCg-based CG₄ sample against three regular-group controls, including the projected-compact-core analogue Control_{4C} – and with seeing-corrected model sizes, a Petrosian cross-check, cluster-robust adjusted models, one-to-one matching, crowding tests, and Holm-corrected confidence intervals.

Under this stricter design, we find no compact-group size offset at fixed stellar mass relative to regular groups. This does not contradict Coenda et al. (2012) directly, because their comparison was against loose groups and the field, whereas ours is against regular-group cores selected from the same parent catalogues.

Three interpretation guardrails apply. A negative Δ at fixed mass can reflect genuine tidal truncation or stripping, a higher bulge dominance in the CG₄ population, or residual measurement blending in crowded fields. The morphology-stratified fits address the second possibility, the Petrosian cross-check and the measure-difference diagnostic address the third, and the crowding exclusions bound the sensitivity of all size coefficients to the closest projected pairs. Any future claim of compact-group size evolution should be read through those three blocks together rather than through a single pooled coefficient.

6.3. Smooth morphologies, S0 degeneracy, and transition galaxies

The Galaxy Zoo morphology variables used here separate smooth, featureless systems from galaxies with visible spiral structure or other features. They do not cleanly distinguish classical ellipticals from S0 galaxies, faded disks, or other smooth disk-dominated systems. The enhanced CG₄ elliptical/smooth fraction should therefore be interpreted as a shift toward smooth or early-type-like appearances, not as proof that compact groups specifically build classical elliptical galaxies.

This caveat is important when comparing with the recent S-PLUS structural studies of compact-group galaxies by Montaguth et al. (2023, 2025, 2026a,b). Those studies identify transition galaxies and trends in the R_e –Sérsic-index and mass-size planes, with especially strong signals in non-isolated compact groups and host structures. Their transition population can plausibly overlap with the smooth class in our catalogue: systems with faded disks, increasing central concentration, or S0-like structure may be counted as smooth here even if they are not classical ellipticals. The two approaches are therefore complementary. Their structural measurements describe the likely physical form of the transformation, while our regular-group controls show that the strongest residual compact-group signal is the accumulated smooth/featured morphology balance. With the Simard structural parameters now attached to this sample, the R_e –Sérsic- n plane is measured directly for CG₄ and its controls (Appendix Fig. D.17), turning this comparison with the S-PLUS transition-galaxy studies from a qualitative statement into a direct one.

6.4. Decoupling between morphology and instantaneous star formation

The star-formation diagnostics do not follow the morphology signal one-to-one. CG₄ satellites have a lower raw star-forming fraction, especially relative to RG₄, but the adjusted evidence is control-dependent (significant only against Control_{4B}) and the matched contrasts provide no evidence for a quenched-fraction difference. Among galaxies that remain star-forming, the main-sequence residuals do not show a robust compact-group offset. The colour analysis is also control-sensitive and based on a biased colour-matched subset, while AGN-like fractions, magnitude gaps, and the limited H α diagnostic do not identify a simple alternative driver.

The star-formation non-detections are also limited by the spectroscopy. CG₄ has a higher fraction of galaxies with a nearest projected neighbour below the 55-arcsec

SDSS fibre-collision scale than the controls (19.4% versus 9.2%). The control value is pooled over the regular-control comparison; the Control_{4C}-only exclusion fraction in Sect. 5.3 is larger (12.8%) because Control_{4C} is selected as the compact-core analogue. Spectra are therefore preferentially incomplete in the closest projected pairs, and short-lived interaction-triggered starbursts or post-starburst phases could be underrepresented. The MPA-JHU aperture corrections use photometric information outside the fibre (Brinchmann et al. 2004; Kauffmann et al. 2003a); these corrections may be less secure for interacting or blended compact-group members. We therefore treat the sSFR, SFMS, and H α results as conservative secondary non-detections, not as proof that compact groups have no star-formation effect.

This decoupling suggests that the dominant observable difference is not an instantaneous quenching event caught at the present epoch. A galaxy can lose visible spiral structure, build a smoother disk or bulge-dominated profile, or fade into an S0-like state on timescales that do not require a simultaneously large sSFR residual in the surviving star-forming subset. The present data therefore favour a cumulative morphology or structure signal over a single ongoing star-formation process.

6.5. Compact groups as dense cores and preprocessing sites

The comparison samples were designed to ask whether compact groups remain special relative to ordinary group cores, not merely relative to the field. The answer is mixed but physically useful. CG₄ galaxies retain a robust morphology difference, yet much of the interpretation points toward local density, dense cores, and preprocessing rather than toward an isolated compact-group channel. This is consistent with the construction result that many compact groups are embedded in or associated with larger structures, and with the stronger structural signatures reported for non-isolated compact groups in recent S-PLUS work. We note that no harmonised halo-mass estimate is available for these catalogues (Sect. 5.13), so, although the adjusted models control for group luminosity and velocity dispersion, a residual halo-mass contribution to the morphology signal cannot be fully excluded.

The most conservative interpretation is that compact groups identify the high-density, high-interaction tail of group environments. Some systems may be genuinely compact and dynamically evolved, while others may be dense cores or substructures inside larger haloes. In both cases, the relevant physical quantity is likely the accumulated local interaction history. Future simulations and direct structural measurements, including R_e , Sérsic index, transition-galaxy classifications, and mass-size residuals, are needed to test whether the signal isolated here is unique to compact configurations or is the high-density limit of more general group preprocessing.

7. Conclusion

We have tested whether galaxies in CG₄ compact groups remain special after removing split systems and comparing them with three regular-group analogues: RG₄, Control_{4B}, and Control_{4C}. The comparison was designed to separate compact configurations from ordinary four-member groups,

luminous group cores, and projected compact cores around BGGs.

The main result is morphological, and it is control-dependent in an informative way. CG₄ galaxies have an enhanced elliptical/smooth Galaxy Zoo fraction and a reduced spiral/features fraction. In the per-control adjusted models this signal is strong against the luminous cores of richer ordinary groups (Control_{4B}) and against true four-member groups (RG₄), but weak and non-significant against BGG-centred projected cores (Control_{4C}). At the group level, matched CG₄ groups host a higher smooth-satellite fraction than matched control groups; the galaxy-level matched contrast points in the same direction but is not significant after correction once the four galaxies of a group are treated as one resampling unit. The signal is robust to the Galaxy Zoo vote threshold, is recovered with a threshold-free vote-fraction model and a Sérsic-index cross-check, and is primarily carried by satellites; BGG morphology is not significantly different after adjustment. Within shared host groups, CG₄ members show no significant morphology excess over other members of the same host at fixed mass, rank, and host-centric radius.

The star-formation result is weaker. CG₄ satellites have a lower raw star-forming fraction, especially relative to RG₄, but the adjusted evidence is control-dependent (significant only against Control_{4B}) and the matched contrasts provide no evidence for a quenched-fraction difference. Among galaxies that remain star-forming, CG₄ galaxies do not show a robust offset from the fitted star-forming main sequence.

The galaxy-size test adds a structural dimension to this comparison. At fixed stellar mass, redshift, and group-scale covariates, we find no significant CG₄ offset in seeing-corrected half-light radius, in either the adjusted models or the matched pairs.

The secondary diagnostics do not identify a simple alternative driver. The colour results are control-sensitive and based on a biased colour-matched subset. AGN-like fractions and magnitude gaps do not explain the morphology signal, the H α diagnostic is limited by missing age-sensitive spectral indices, and projected phase-space trends do not localize the quenched difference uniquely to the nearest satellites. The Galaxy Zoo crowding check shows that the smooth/elliptical excess persists after excluding the closest projected pairs, so the result is not solely a closest-pair classification artefact.

We therefore interpret CG₄ galaxies as a more morphologically evolved population, consistent with accumulated transformation in dense group cores and/or preprocessing rather than with compact-group membership as such: the excess vanishes against projected-core controls and within shared hosts, and conditioning on a local projected-density proxy attenuates the coefficient (a conditional attenuation that, by construction, cannot establish mediation). The result should not be read as evidence for a uniquely isolated compact-group quenching mechanism.

This paper now connects the regular-group control framework directly to structural measurements – R_e , Sérsic index, and mass-size residuals through the Simard catalogue – so the remaining structural future work concerns transition-galaxy classifications and better spectroscopic post-starburst diagnostics. The concentration-index check based on $R_{90,r}/R_{50,r}$ is likewise measured here: the adjusted satellite coefficient is 0.065 (Holm-corrected $p = 0.413$), so

this independent structural proxy shows no significant CG₄ offset at fixed mass. Those remaining measurements would test whether the morphology signal isolated here is the same cumulative structural transformation highlighted by recent S-PLUS studies.

Data availability

The input data are drawn from public SDSS spectroscopic and photometric tables, the MPA-JHU value-added catalogues, Galaxy Zoo classifications, the Simard et al. (2011) structural catalogue (VizieR J/ApJS/196/11), and the public group and compact-group catalogues cited in Sect. 2. The derived galaxy and group tables from this analysis will be made available through the CDS at publication. The full analysis and paper-generation code is available at https://github.com/MatthieuTricottet/CG_Gals; the release corresponding to this article will be archived with a DOI (e.g. Zenodo) at acceptance.

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Appendix A: SDSS data query

The SQL query used to retrieve the spectral and photometric quantities from SDSS is listed below.

```

1  SELECT
2      s.specObjID,
3      s.z,
4      p.petroMag_r - p.extinction_r AS
5          r_obs,
6      p.petroMag_u - p.extinction_u AS
7          u_obs,
8      p.petroMag_g - p.extinction_g AS
9          g_obs,
10     p.petroMag_i - p.extinction_i AS
11     i_obs,
12     p.petroMag_z - p.extinction_z AS
13     z_obs,
14     p.objID,
15     g.sfr_tot_p50, g.specsfr_tot_p50, g.
16     lgm_tot_p50,
17     l.h_alpha_eqw, l.h_beta_eqw, l.
18     oiii_5007_eqw, l.nii_6584_eqw,
19     l.h_alpha_flux, l.h_beta_flux, l.
20     oiii_5007_flux, l.nii_6584_flux,
21     z.p_el_debiased AS p_E,
22     z.p_cs_debiased AS p_S
23 FROM SpecObj AS s
24 JOIN PhotoObj AS p ON s.bestObjID = p
25     .objID
26 JOIN galSpecExtra as g ON s.specObjID
27     = g.specObjID
28 JOIN galSpecLine as l ON s.specObjID
29     = l.specObjID
30 JOIN zooSpec AS z ON s.specObjID = z.
31     specObjID
32 WHERE s.z BETWEEN 0.005 AND 0.0452
33 AND (p.petroMag_r - p.extinction_r <=
34     17.77)
35 AND s.class = 'GALAXY'
36 AND g.lgm_tot_p50 > -1000

```

Listing 1. Query used for selecting spectral & photometric data from the SDSS

Appendix B: sSFR classification details

We identify BPT-classifiable galaxies by requiring measured values of both emission-line ratios

$$\log_{10}([\text{N II}]\lambda 6584/\text{H}\alpha) \quad \text{and} \quad \log_{10}([\text{O III}]\lambda 5007/\text{H}\beta).$$

Among these galaxies, we flag AGN-like systems if they satisfy either

$$\log_{10} \frac{[\text{N II}]}{\text{H}\alpha} > 0,$$

or if they lie above the empirical demarcation of [Kauffmann et al. \(2003a\)](#):

$$\log_{10} \frac{[\text{O III}]}{\text{H}\beta} > \frac{0.61}{\log_{10}([\text{N II}]/\text{H}\alpha) - 0.05} + 1.3,$$

in which case they are excluded from the GMM calibration sample. This calibration flag is deliberately more inclusive than the three-class BPT scheme of Sect. 5.10, in which composite galaxies lie between the [Kauffmann et al. \(2003a\)](#) and [Kewley et al. \(2001\)](#) demarcations and only galaxies above the [Kewley et al. \(2001\)](#) line are labelled AGN-like, because its sole purpose is to keep possible AGN contamination out of the sSFR calibration. Galaxies with missing diagnostic line ratios are BPT-unclassified, not proven non-AGN. They are retained for the broad sSFR status assignment when valid SDSS stellar mass and sSFR estimates are available, while the emission-line/AGN-like analysis treats BPT-unclassified objects separately. The BPT-classifiable subset is shown in Fig. B.1.

Galaxies with `specsfr_tot_p50` equal to `-9999` in the SDSS have no valid sSFR estimate; they are treated as missing data throughout: excluded from the GMM calibration, never assigned an sSFR class, omitted from every sSFR figure, and reported as counts only (Sect. 2.2). Galaxies with a measured sSFR are divided into quenched and star-forming classes with a two-component Gaussian Mixture Model (GMM) in the $\log M_{\star}$ - $\log$ sSFR plane ([McLachlan & Peel 2000](#)). The calibration excludes galaxies flagged as AGN-like where the required BPT line ratios are available, while BPT-unclassified galaxies with valid SDSS stellar mass and sSFR estimates can still receive a broad sSFR class. The quenched/star-forming boundary is the locus where the two component posterior probabilities are equal. A fixed-threshold robustness check confirms that the qualitative hierarchy is not tied to the exact GMM split.

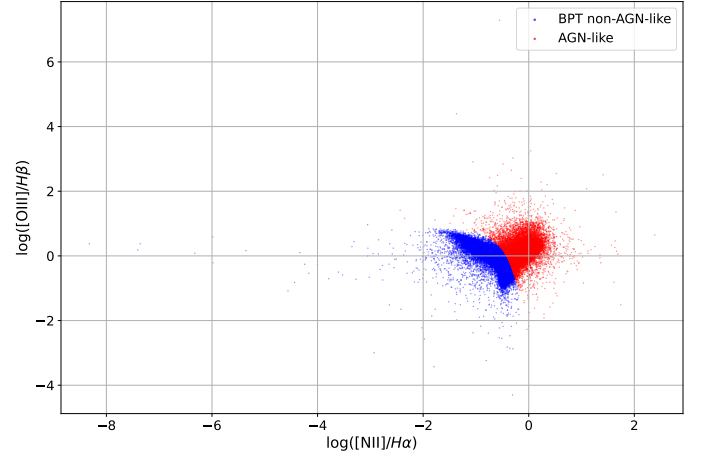


Fig. B.1. BPT diagram for galaxies with measured diagnostic line ratios. The AGN-like region is excluded from the sSFR calibration sample; galaxies without the required ratios are BPT-unclassified rather than classified as non-AGN by this diagram.

Table C.1. CG₄ galaxies inside would-be Control_{4C} quartets of the parent catalogue, by compact-group class.

CG ₄ class	CG ₄ groups	Lim groups	Galaxies
Embedded	37 / 37	37	116
Isolated	6 / 6	6	24
Predominant	13 / 19	13	40
Split	4 / 16	4	12

Notes. “CG₄ groups” counts compact groups with at least one member inside a parent-group quartet, over the total number of compact groups of that class (split groups included, as in the exclusion).

Appendix C: Compact groups as projected cores of ordinary groups

The compact-group exclusion of Sect. 2.1 is not a technicality: for 60 of the 765 parent Lim groups, the would-be Control_{4C} quartet (BGG plus three closest projected companions) contains at least one CG₄ galaxy — 192 CG₄ galaxies in total. Table C.1 breaks this overlap down by the Zheng & Shen (2021) embeddedness class: essentially every Embedded and Predominant compact group *is* the projected core of an ordinary group. Had these groups not been excluded, the same galaxies would have appeared on both sides of the comparisons, biasing every contrast toward null.

Appendix D: Supplementary diagnostic figures

This appendix collects the secondary diagnostic figures referenced in the main text.

D.1. sSFR and main-sequence diagnostics

Figures D.1–D.4 show the residual-sSFR distribution, the property distributions split by sSFR class (for all galaxies and for satellites by BGG class), and the polynomial-order comparison for the star-forming main sequence.

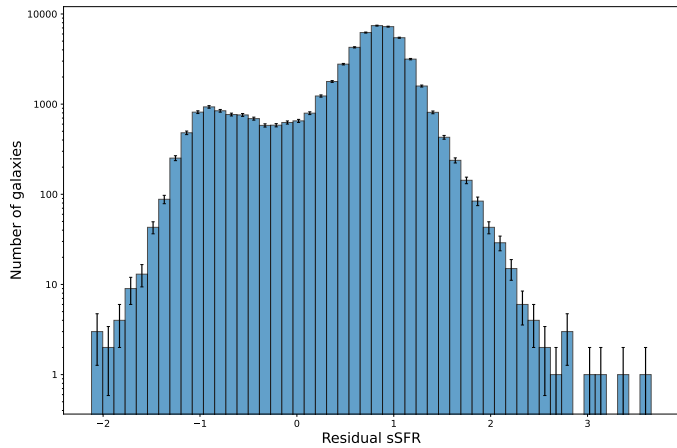


Fig. D.1. Distribution of residual sSFR offsets from the adopted star-forming main sequence.

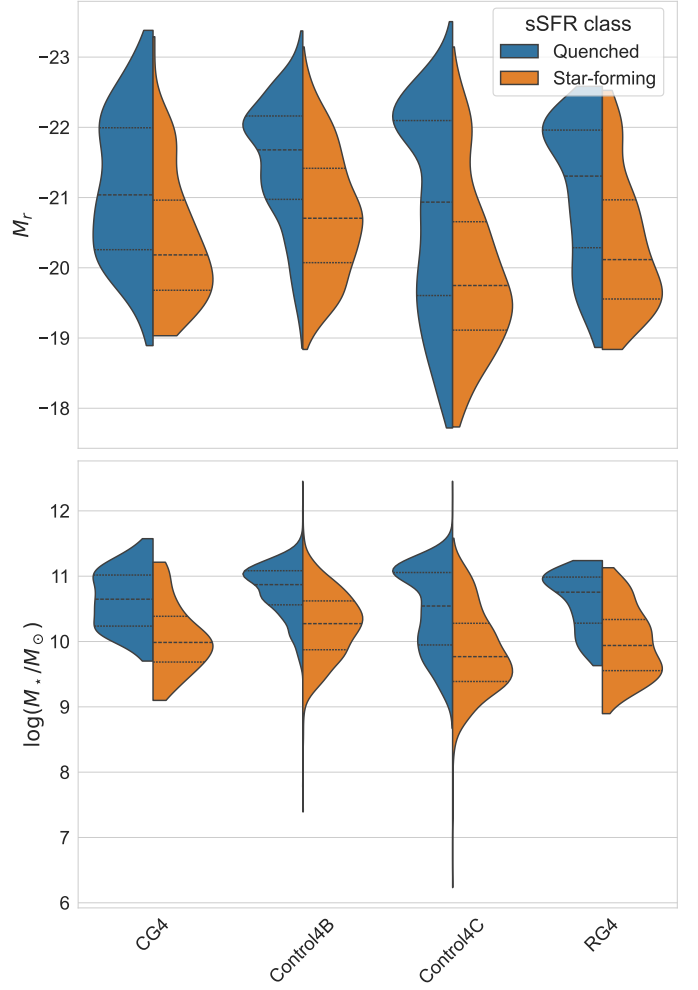


Fig. D.2. Distributions of various quantities for galaxies according to their sSFR class.

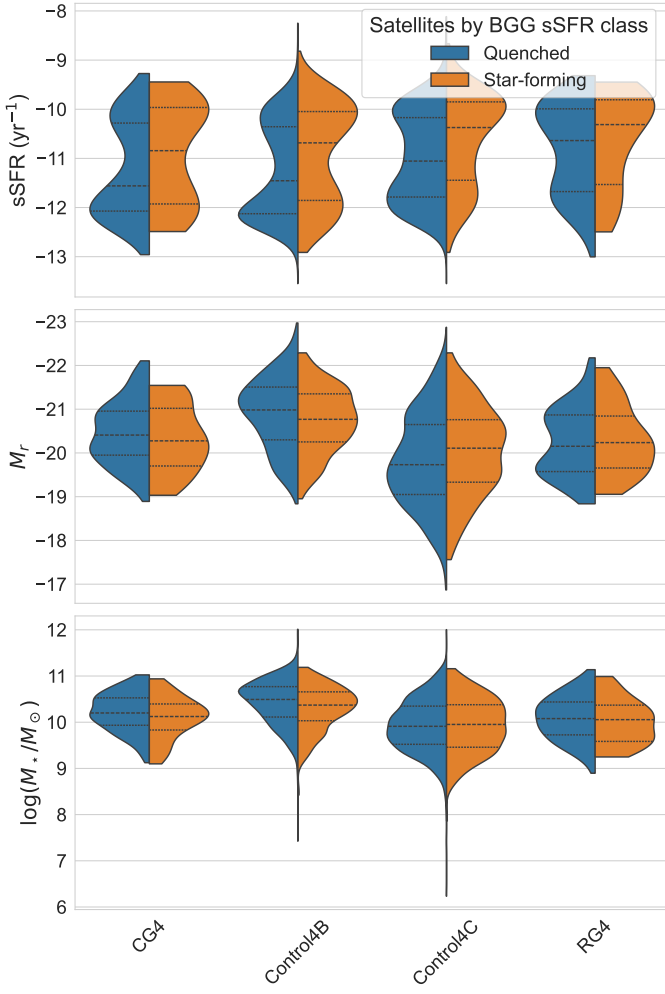


Fig. D.3. Distributions of various quantities for satellites according to the BGG sSFR class.

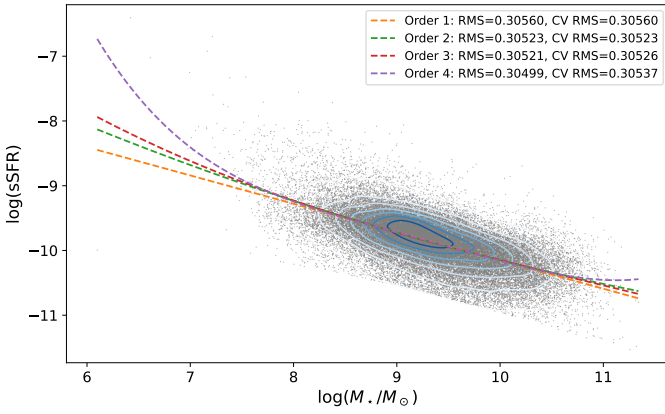


Fig. D.4. Polynomial fits of orders 1–4 to the star-forming main sequence. The legend reports residual RMS and five-fold cross-validated RMS scatter in dex; order 2 is adopted because it is the lowest-order model with the smallest cross-validated RMS scatter.

D.2. Group-scale and radial diagnostics

Figures D.5 and D.6 show the sSFR–distance relations, Figs. D.7 and D.8 the domination diagnostics, and Fig. D.9 the crossing-time trend.

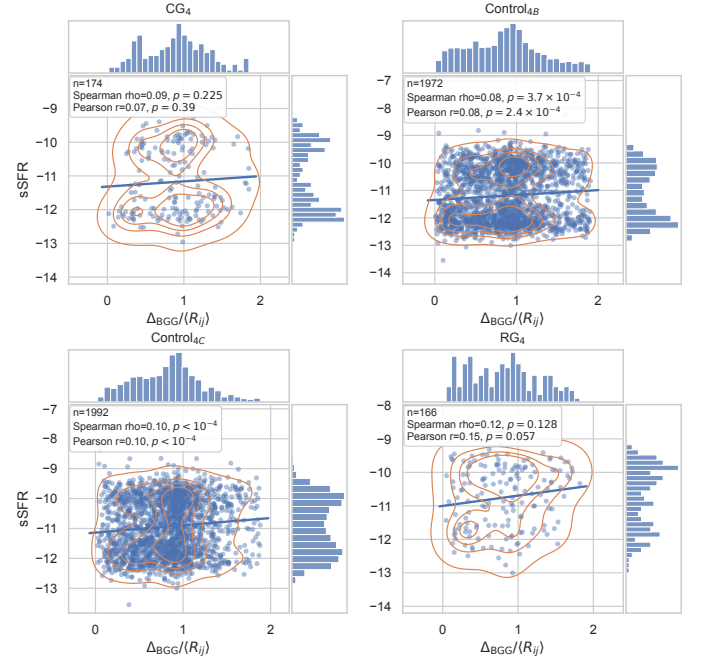


Fig. D.6. sSFR as a function of projected distance to the BGG normalized by $\langle R_{ij} \rangle$ for satellite galaxies in each sample.

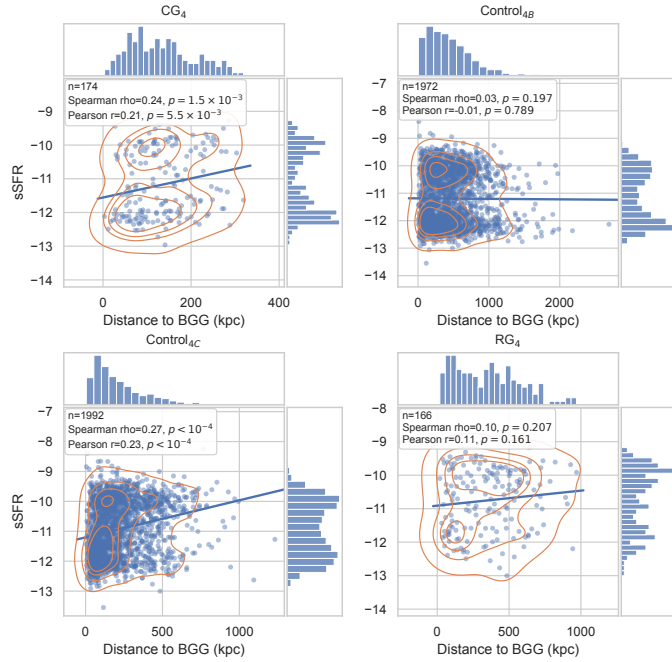


Fig. D.5. sSFR as a function of projected distance to the BGG, in kpc, for satellite galaxies in each sample.

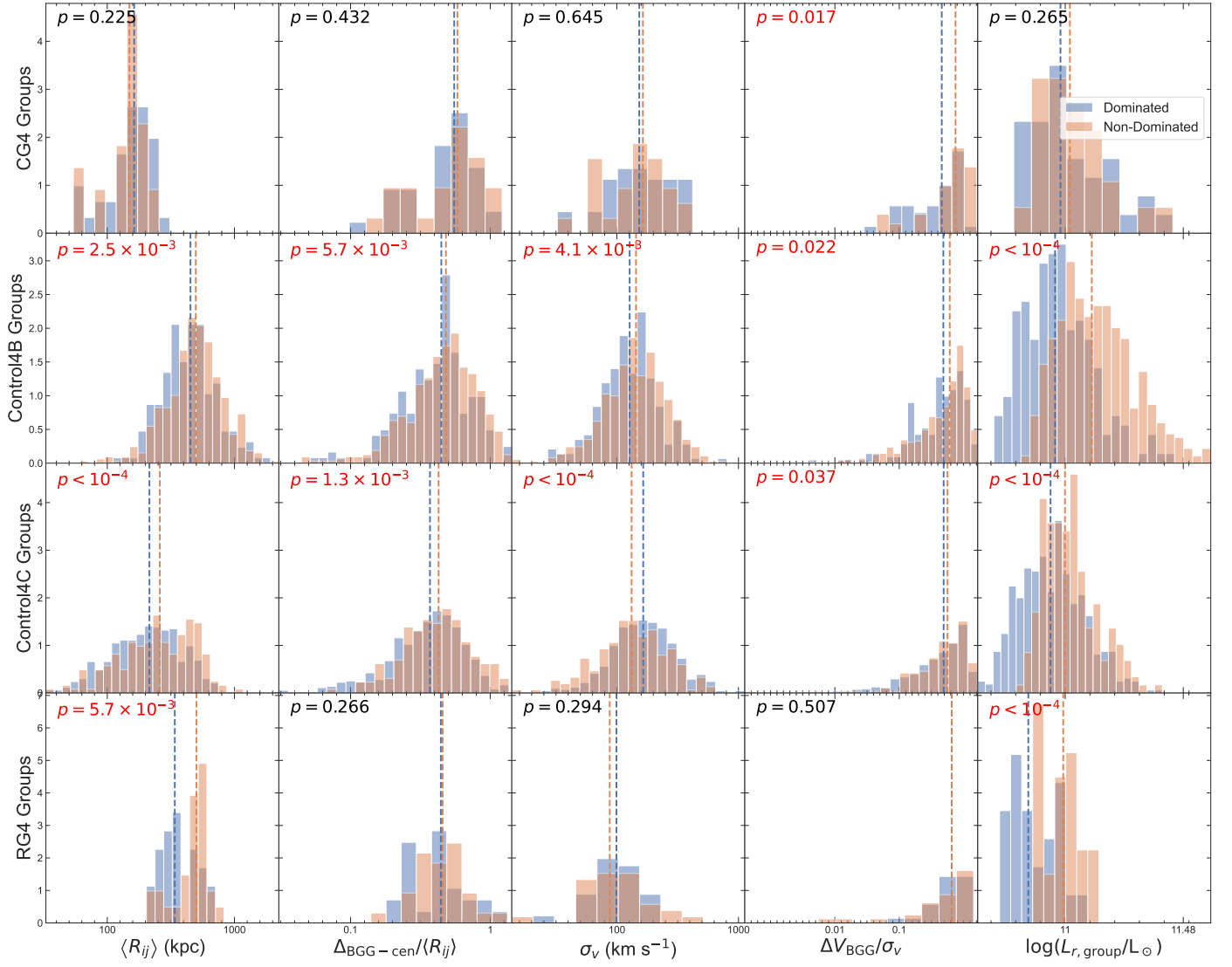


Fig. D.7. Distributions of the main group-scale observables in dominated and non-dominated systems.

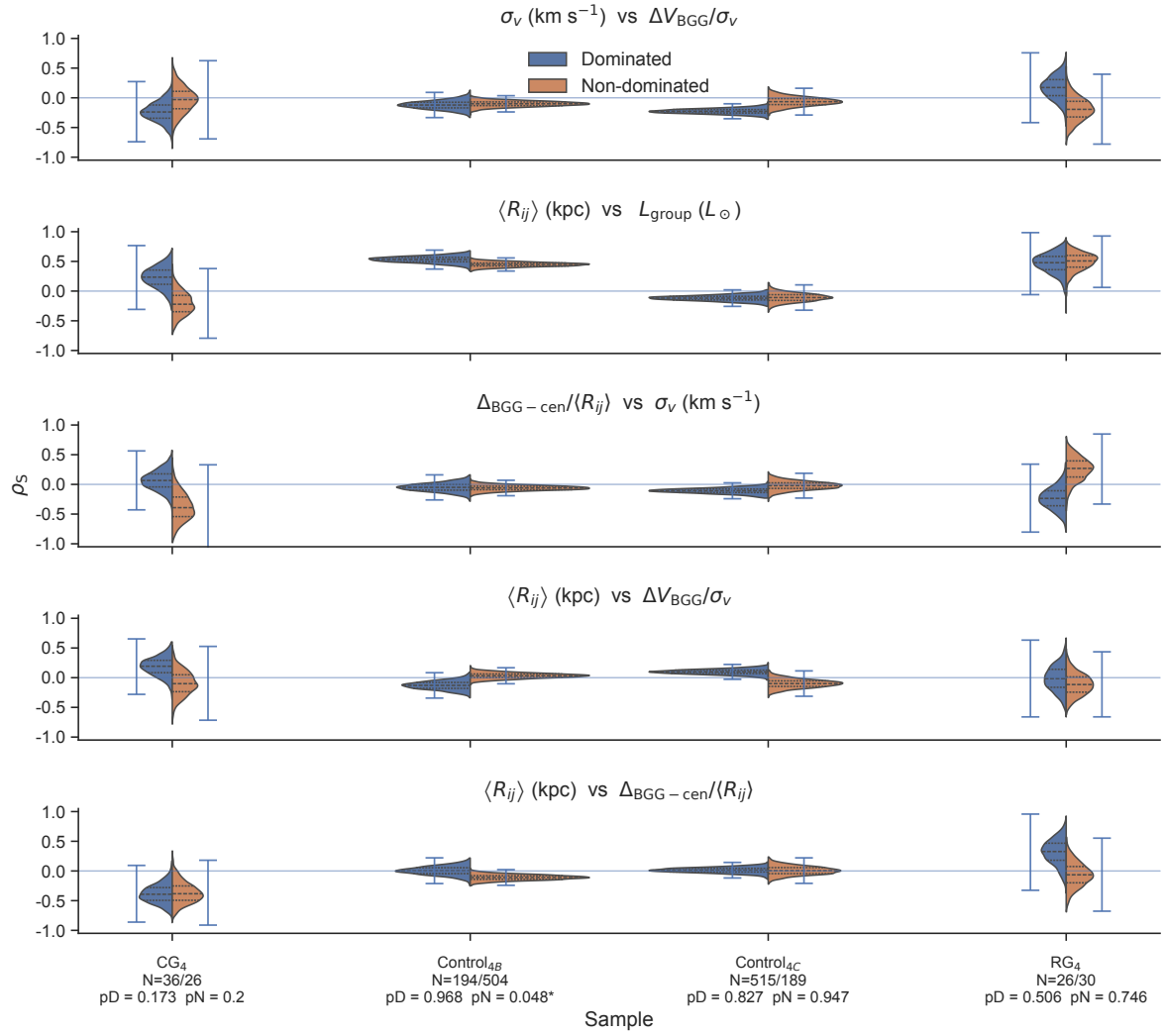


Fig. D.8. Bootstrap distributions of the Spearman coefficients for the group-property pairs selected by the XOR domination criterion, i.e. property pairs whose Spearman correlation, after a per-subsample Benjamini–Hochberg adjustment across pairs, is significant ($p_{\text{adj}} < 0.10$) in exactly one of the dominated and non-dominated subsamples of at least one sample.

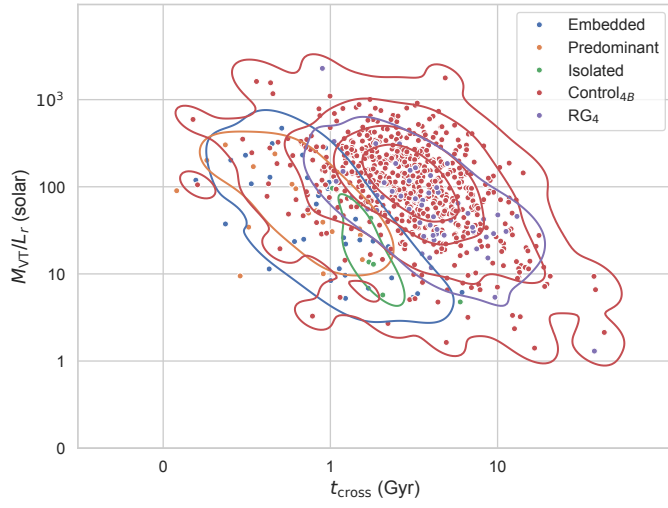


Fig. D.9. Crossing time versus virial mass-to-light ratio for the compact groups and their controls.

D.3. Colour diagnostics

1570 Figures D.10–D.12 show the colour–mass relations of the catalogues, the satellite colour–mass comparison, and the mass- and redshift-adjusted colour residuals versus BGG-centric distance.

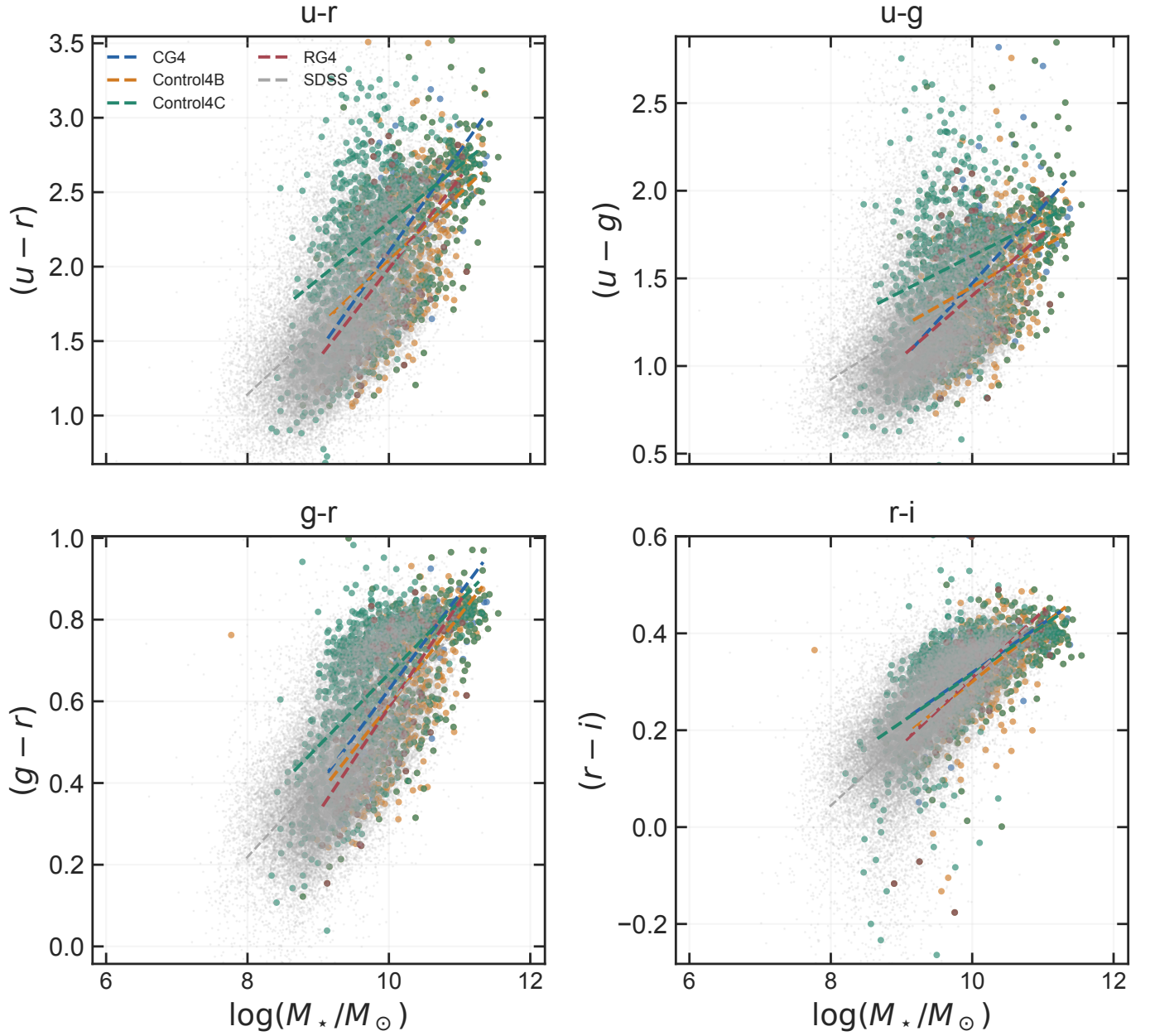


Fig. D.10. Optical colour as a function of stellar mass for CG₄, the three control catalogues, and the matched SDSS reference sample. Dashed lines show the fitted catalogue relations.

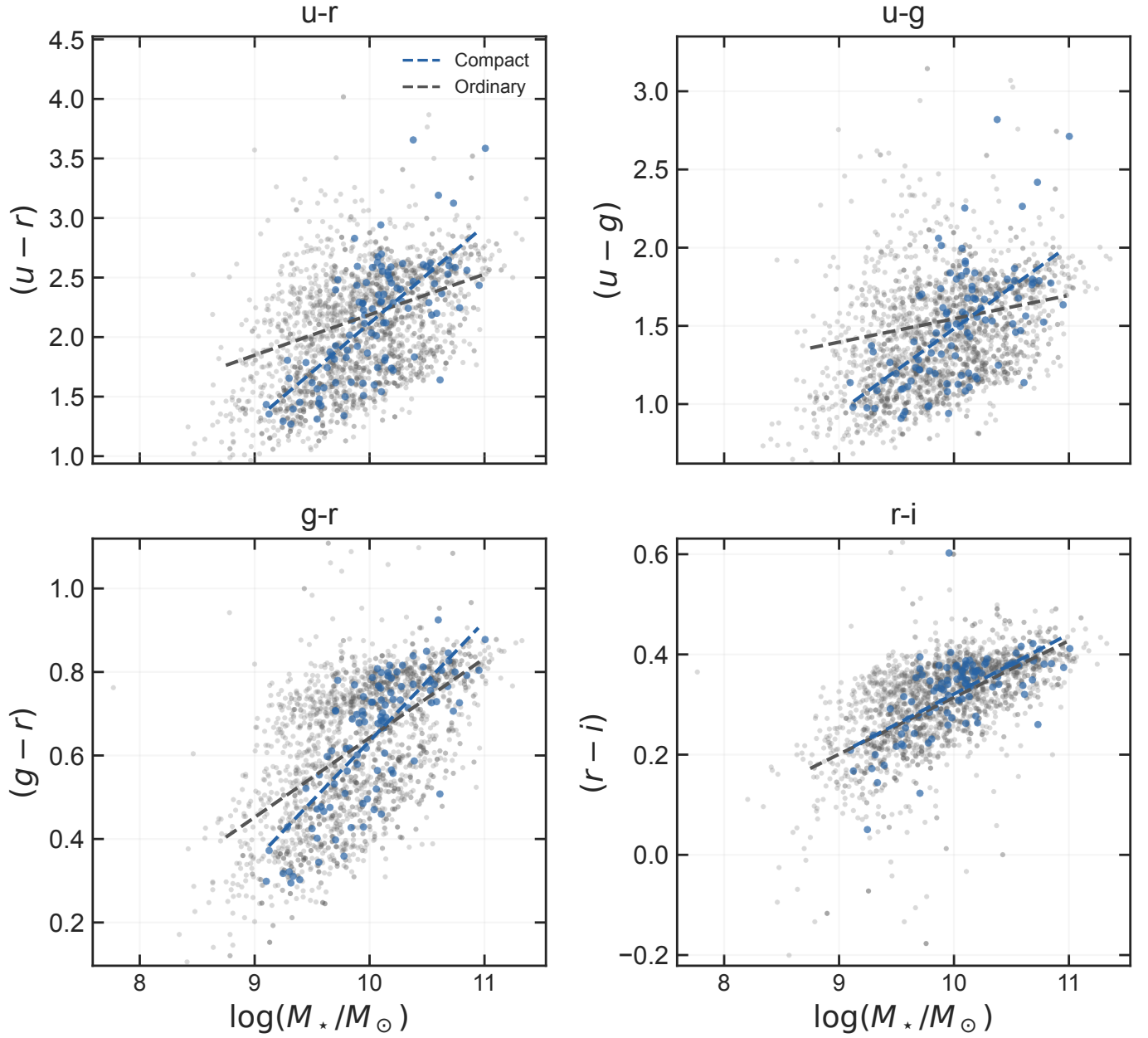


Fig. D.11. Satellite colour–mass relations in compact and ordinary groups. The fitted lines show both colour offsets at the reference mass and differences in slope.

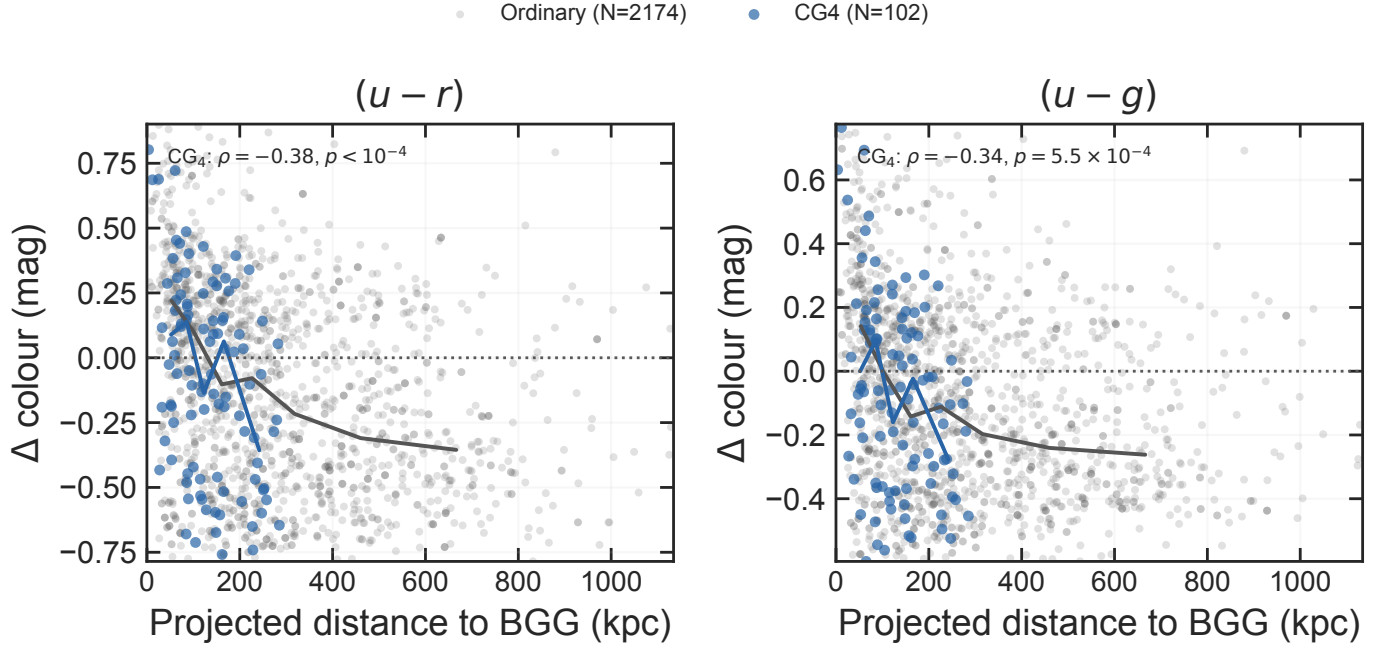


Fig. D.12. Mass- and redshift-adjusted satellite $(u-r)$ and $(u-g)$ residuals as a function of projected distance to the BGG. Lines connect binned medians for CG₄ and the pooled ordinary-group satellites; extreme plotting tails are omitted for readability, while the reported rank correlations use the full matched sample. More negative residuals are bluer than the ordinary-satellite reference relation.

D.4. Size diagnostics

Figures D.13–D.18 show the availability audit of the two size measures, the mass–size relations, the per-control size coefficients, the Simard–Petrosian measure difference, the R_e –Sérsic- n plane, and the radial size-residual diagnostic.

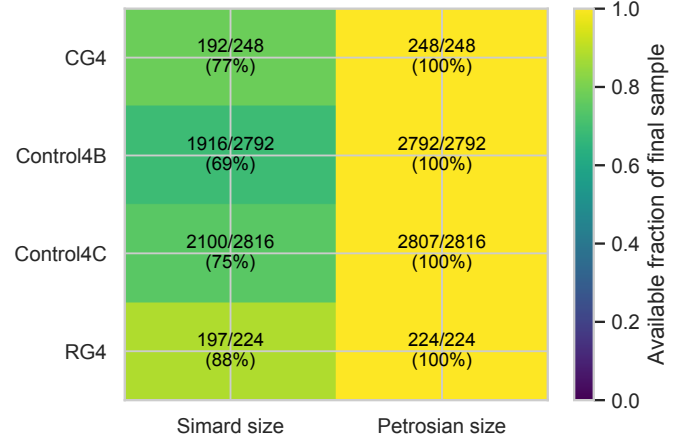


Fig. D.13. Availability of the seeing-corrected Simard half-light radius and the Petrosian half-light radius in each sample, after the bridge, quality, and blending cuts of Sect. 2.4.

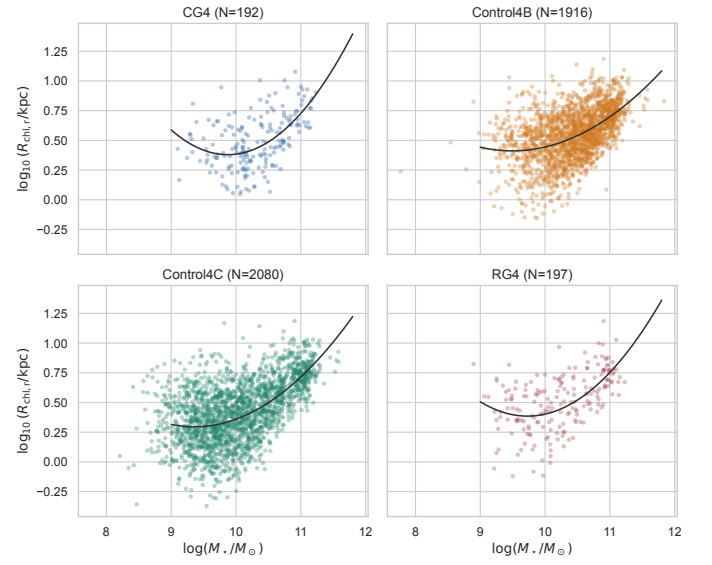


Fig. D.14. Seeing-corrected half-light radius versus stellar mass in each sample. Solid curves show the descriptive quadratic fits used to quote a predicted size at the reference stellar mass.

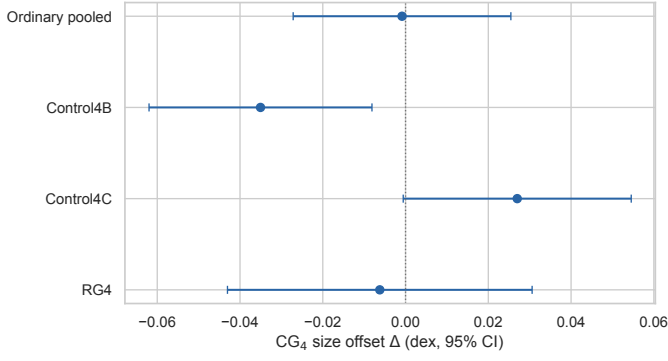


Fig. D.15. Mass- and redshift-adjusted CG_4 size coefficients against the pooled controls and against each control catalogue separately. Bars show 95% confidence intervals; negative values mean smaller CG_4 sizes at fixed mass.

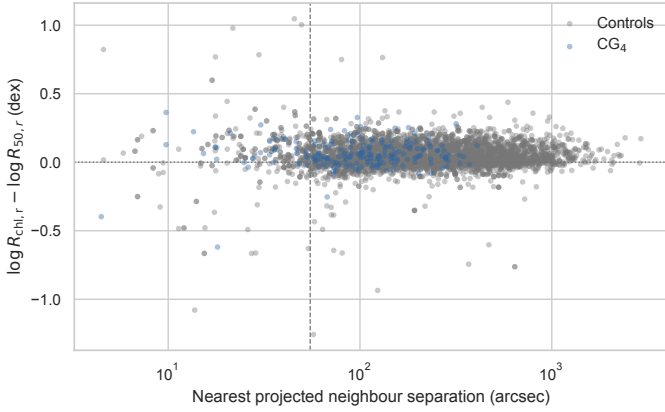


Fig. D.16. Per-galaxy difference between the Simard and Petrosian log half-light radii as a function of nearest projected neighbour separation. The dashed line marks the 55-arcsec crowding scale.

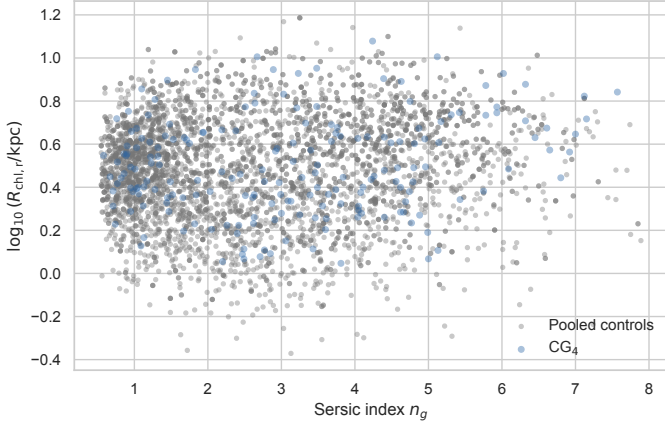


Fig. D.17. Half-light radius versus Sérsic index for CG_4 and the pooled controls, the plane used by the S-PLUS transition-galaxy studies.

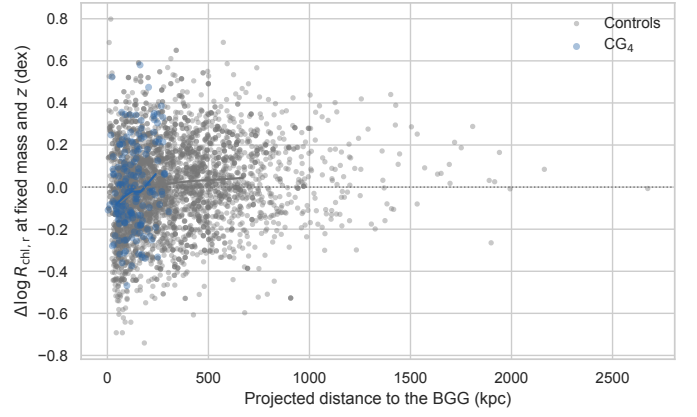


Fig. D.18. Mass- and redshift-adjusted satellite size residuals versus projected distance to the BGG. Lines connect binned medians for CG_4 and the pooled controls.

D.5. Robustness and selection diagnostics

Figures D.19–D.25 show the projected phase-space bins, the magnitude-gap diagnostics, the $H\alpha$ equivalent-width distributions, the AGN-like fractions, the availability audit, and the colour-selection mass audit.

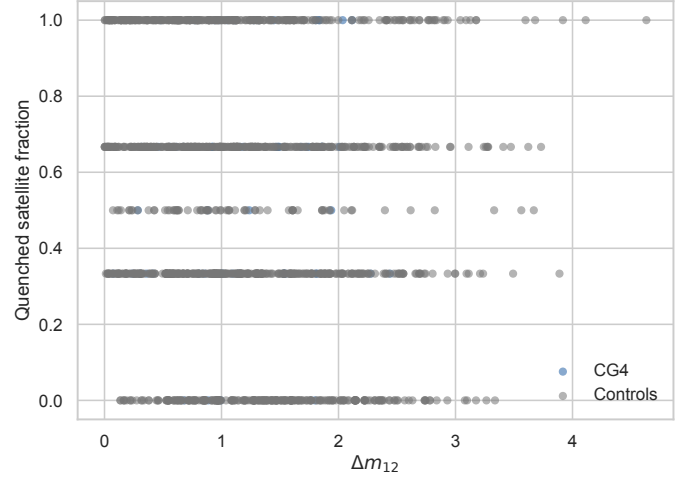


Fig. D.21. Quenched satellite fraction as a function of the first-second magnitude gap.

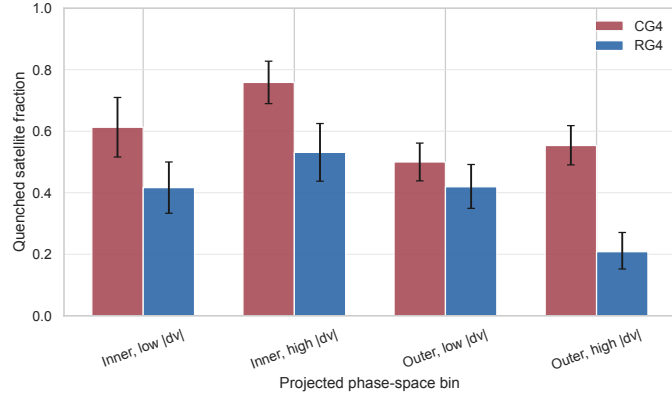


Fig. D.19. Quenched satellite fraction in coarse projected phase-space bins. Inner and outer refer to projected-distance rank from the BGG; low and high velocity are split at $|\Delta v_{\text{BGG}}|/\sigma_v = 1$.

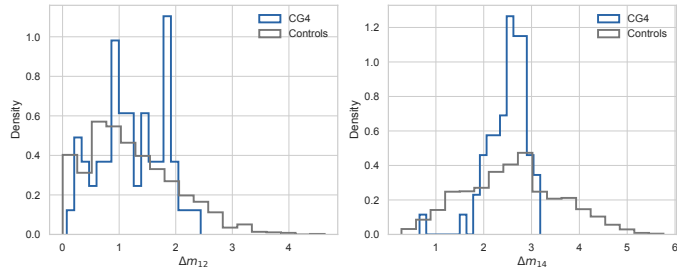


Fig. D.20. Distributions of the first-second and first-fourth magnitude gaps in CG₄ and the pooled controls.

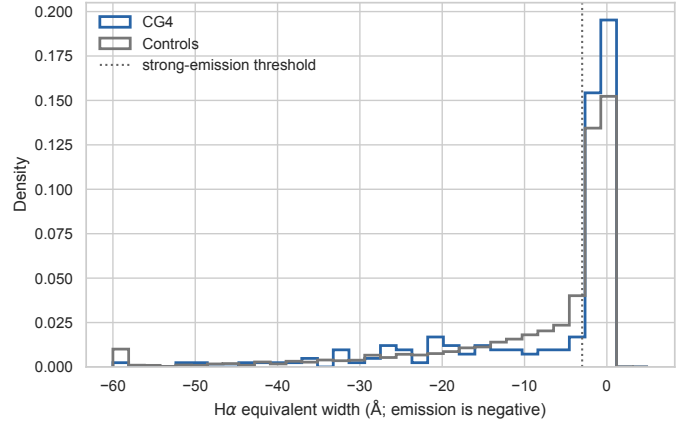


Fig. D.22. $H\alpha$ equivalent-width distributions used for the limited recent-quenching diagnostic.

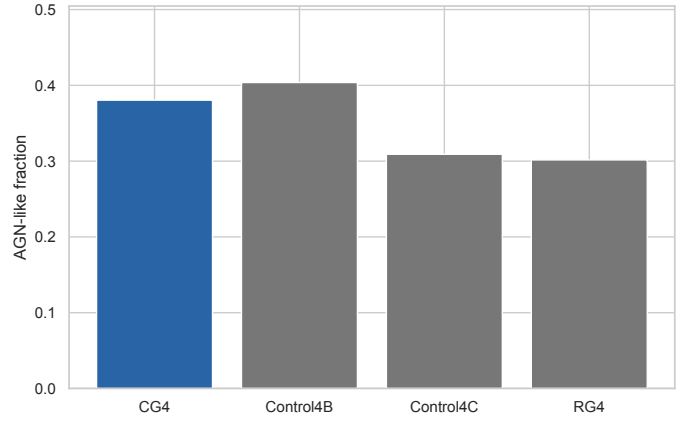


Fig. D.23. AGN-like fractions among galaxies with BPT-classifiable emission-line ratios. BPT-unclassified galaxies are not counted as non-AGN in this diagnostic.

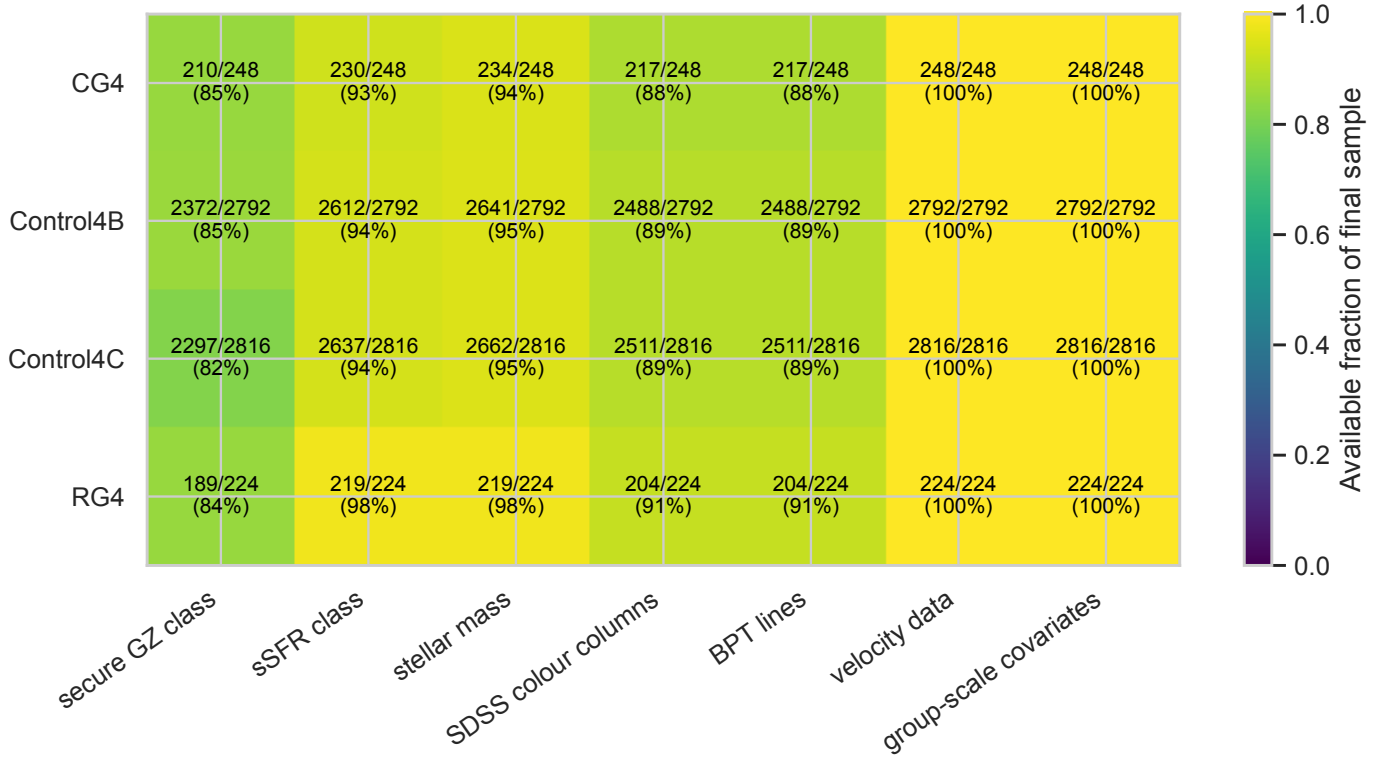


Fig. D.24. Availability fractions for the major derived quantities in each sample. The colour row records completeness of the four derived SDSS colour columns in the final catalogue, rather than the stricter colour-analysis matched subset used in Sect. 4.6.

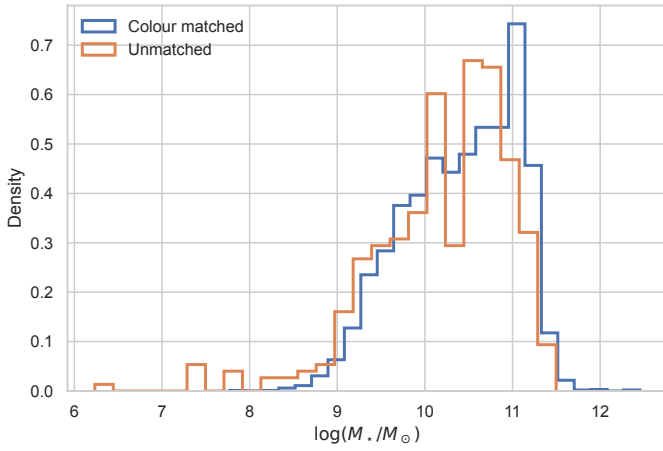


Fig. D.25. Stellar-mass distributions of galaxies with and without complete matched colour measurements.